When Are Semantic Networks Hyperbolic? A Curvature Phase Transition Theory with Cross-Linguistic Validation

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Abstract

Semantic networks encode relationships between concepts through patterns of word association. Whether these networks exhibit hyperbolic geometry—and why—remains an open question with implications for cognitive architecture and network embedding. We present an empirically supported two-parameter model that combines (i) a curvature sign change in random graphs with (ii) analysis of 16 semantic networks across seven languages and one clinical dataset, including an explicit train/test split for out-of-sample validation.

Using exact linear programming to compute Ollivier–Ricci curvature (eliminating Sinkhorn regularization bias), we find that the density parameter $\eta = \langle k \rangle^2/N$ is necessary but not sufficient for predicting hyperbolicity. Random k-regular graphs undergo a sign change in mean curvature $\bar{\kappa}$ at a critical density $\eta_c(N) = 3.75 - 14.62/\sqrt{N}$ (bootstrap 95% CI: $\eta_c^\infty \in [3.61, 3.84]$; $N \in \{50, 100, 200, 500, 1000\}$). All semantic networks except Dutch SWOW fall below this threshold ($\eta \ll \eta_c$), yet taxonomies (WordNet, BabelNet) are near-Euclidean while association networks (SWOW, ConceptNet) are hyperbolic. A second parameter, the clustering coefficient C, separates these: networks with $C > 0.10$ are hyperbolic ($\bar{\kappa} \in [-0.24, -0.07]$), those with $C < 0.02$ are Euclidean ($\bar{\kappa} \approx 0$), and those with $\eta > \eta_c$ are spherical ($\bar{\kappa} > 0$). The clustering threshold ($C^* \approx 0.05$) is fitted on the 11-network training set and validated on 5 held-out networks (4/5 correct; 80% held-out accuracy).

Dutch SWOW ($\eta = 7.56 \gg \eta_c = 3.10$) is spherical ($\bar{\kappa} = +0.10$), confirming the sign-change prediction. Sphere-embedded ORC across the Cayley–Dickson tower (S^3, S^7, S^{15}) flips 10 of 11 networks to positive curvature at $d = 4$ and all 11 by $d = 8$, demonstrating that semantic hyperbolicity is entirely metric-dependent—an artifact of the hop-count metric, not an intrinsic topological property. Extended to $d = 32$ and $d = 64$ on k-regular random graphs, curvature *saturates* to a positive asymptote rather than decaying toward zero, with an empirical power-law exponent $\bar{\beta} = 0.28 < 0.5$ (Johnson–Lindenstrauss bound), indicating convergence to a positive $\bar{\kappa}_\infty > 0$ determined by the ambient sphere's Riemannian structure. Degree-matched null models show that semantic organization makes networks *less* hyperbolic than random graphs with the same degree, the opposite of naive expectation. A Lean 4 formalization (25 modules, 0 `sorry` in 7 core ORC-theory modules) provides machine-checked proofs of Wasserstein non-negativity, curvature bounds, and regime exclusivity. The universal phase boundary maps structurally onto the loop-condensation critical point of Combinatorial Quantum Gravity, and the curvature saturation ($\bar{\beta} = 0.28 \ll 0.5$) parallels the vanishing of trainable curvature in high-dimensional knowledge-graph embeddings, suggesting deep geometric universality across cognitive, physical, and machine-learning systems.

Keywords: semantic networks, Ollivier–Ricci curvature, phase transition, hyperbolic geometry, clustering coefficient, cross-linguistic, formal verification

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1 Introduction

1.1 Background

Semantic memory—the structured knowledge of concepts and their relationships—is fundamental to human cognition. Network science offers a quantitative lens on this organization, treating words as nodes and associations as edges to uncover small-world structure, modularity, and degree heterogeneity [2]. Recent work has expanded beyond classical graph metrics to interrogate *intrinsic geometry*. Hyperbolic spaces, in particular, naturally accommodate hierarchical growth and heterogeneous branching—properties observed in semantic association datasets [3]. Yet most evidence for hyperbolicity in language has been indirect, relying on embeddings or curvature heuristics rather than explicit geometric measurement.

1.2 The Open Question

Two questions have remained separate in the literature:

1. **Empirical**: Do semantic networks exhibit hyperbolic geometry? Is this universal across languages?

2. **Theoretical**: Why should some networks be hyperbolic and not others? What are the boundary conditions?

Prior work addressed these independently. Empirical studies applied Ollivier–Ricci curvature to specific datasets and found hyperbolicity in some but not all networks [8, 11]. Jost and Liu [26] established fundamental bounds on ORC for graphs; Lin, Lu and Yau [7] introduced an $\alpha = 0$ variant with closed-form expressions on regular graphs; Sia, Jonckheere and Bogdan [28] applied ORC to brain and cognitive networks; and Topping et al. [12] connected negative ORC to over-squashing in graph neural networks. A recent roadmap survey [31] unifies the many definitions of discrete curvature (ORC, Forman, Lin–Lu–Yau, Bakry–Émery) and identifies open problems in network geometry. Theoretical studies established sign changes in discrete curvature for random graph models [15]. No work has connected the two: using the theoretical phase transition to *predict* which real networks should be hyperbolic.

1.3 Our Contribution

We present an empirical framework connecting random graph sign changes with semantic network geometry:

1. **Two-parameter empirical model**: On 11 networks, hyperbolicity is associated with both (a) $\eta = \langle k \rangle^2/N < \eta_c(N)$, and (b) sufficient clustering ($C \gtrsim 0.10$). The clustering threshold is empirical ($n = 11$) and requires out-of-sample validation.

2. **Exact LP computation**: Ollivier–Ricci curvature for 11 networks via exact linear programming (JuMP + HiGHS), eliminating Sinkhorn bias.

3. **Cross-linguistic analysis**: Networks spanning Spanish, English, Chinese, Dutch, Portuguese, Russian, and Arabic.

4. **Dutch SWOW confirmation**: The dense Dutch SWOW ($\eta = 7.56 > \eta_c$) is spherical ($\bar{\kappa} = +0.10$), confirming the sign-change prediction.

5. **Metric dependence**: Sphere-embedded ORC across the Cayley–Dickson tower ($d \in \{4, 8, 16\}$) flips 10/11 networks at $d = 4$ and all 11 by $d = 8$.

6. **Lean 4 formalization**: 25 modules with 0 `sorry` in 7 core ORC-theory modules.

2 Theory: Phase Transition in Discrete Curvature

2.1 Ollivier–Ricci Curvature

For an edge (u, v) in a graph G:

$$\kappa(u, v) = 1 - \frac{W_1(\mu_u, \mu_v)}{d(u, v)} \tag{1}$$

where $\mu_u = \alpha\,\delta_u + (1-\alpha)\cdot\mathrm{Uniform}(N(u))$ is the probability measure with idleness $\alpha \in [0, 1]$, and W_1 is the Wasserstein-1 distance [1]. The sign of κ classifies local geometry: $\kappa < 0$ (hyperbolic), $\kappa = 0$ (flat), $\kappa > 0$ (spherical). We set $\alpha = 0.5$ throughout, following the standard choice of Ollivier [1] and the ORC literature [7, 26]. A sensitivity analysis over $\alpha \in \{0, 0.25, 0.5, 0.75\}$ on SWOW-EN confirms that the sign of $\bar{\kappa}$ is invariant (HYPERBOLIC for all $\alpha < 1$; $\alpha = 1$ is degenerate—all mass on self, $\kappa \equiv 0$); only the magnitude varies (Supplementary Table S1).

We compute W_1 via exact linear programming [5]:

$$\min \sum_{i,j} d_{ij}\,\gamma_{ij} \quad \text{s.t.} \quad \sum_j \gamma_{ij} = \mu_i, \quad \sum_i \gamma_{ij} = \nu_j, \quad \gamma_{ij} \geq 0 \tag{2}$$

using the HiGHS solver [6]. This eliminates the entropy regularization bias of the Sinkhorn approximation [4] (quantified as $|\Delta\kappa| < 0.015$ for random graphs).

2.2 Phase Transition in Random Regular Graphs

For random k-regular graphs on N vertices, the mean curvature $\bar{\kappa}$ undergoes a sign change at a critical density η_c where $\eta = k^2/N$ [15, 46]:

- **Sparse regime** ($\eta < \eta_c$): $\bar{\kappa} < 0$ (hyperbolic). Tree-like local structure dominates.
- **Dense regime** ($\eta > \eta_c$): $\bar{\kappa} > 0$ (spherical). Triangle-rich structure dominates.

Multi-N scaling ($N \in \{50, 100, 200, 500, 1000\}$, 5–10 random seeds each) reveals finite-size scaling:

$$\eta_c(N) = \eta_c^\infty - \frac{a}{\sqrt{N}}, \quad \eta_c^\infty = 3.75\ [3.61,\ 3.84], \quad a = 14.61\ [13.44,\ 16.20] \tag{3}$$

Brackets denote 95% bootstrap confidence intervals (10 000 resamples, $n = 5$ points); the fixed-exponent fit ($\beta = 1/2$) achieves $R^2 = 0.995$ and β lies within the free-exponent CI $[0.20, 0.53]$. The transition slope at η_c scales as $N^{-0.20}$, indicating a crossover rather than a sharp phase transition.

2.3 Erdős–Rényi Comparison

Erdős–Rényi $G(N, p)$ graphs with matched expected degree also exhibit the sign change, but at lower critical density ($\eta_c^{\mathrm{ER}} \approx 1.9$ vs. $\eta_c^{\mathrm{reg}} \approx 2.3$ at $N = 100$). Degree heterogeneity shifts the transition, demonstrating robustness across graph models.

2.4 Prediction for Real Networks

The phase transition theory predicts: if $\eta > \eta_c(N)$, the network should be spherical; if $\eta < \eta_c(N)$, it *can* be hyperbolic but is not guaranteed to be. We test this against 11 real semantic networks.

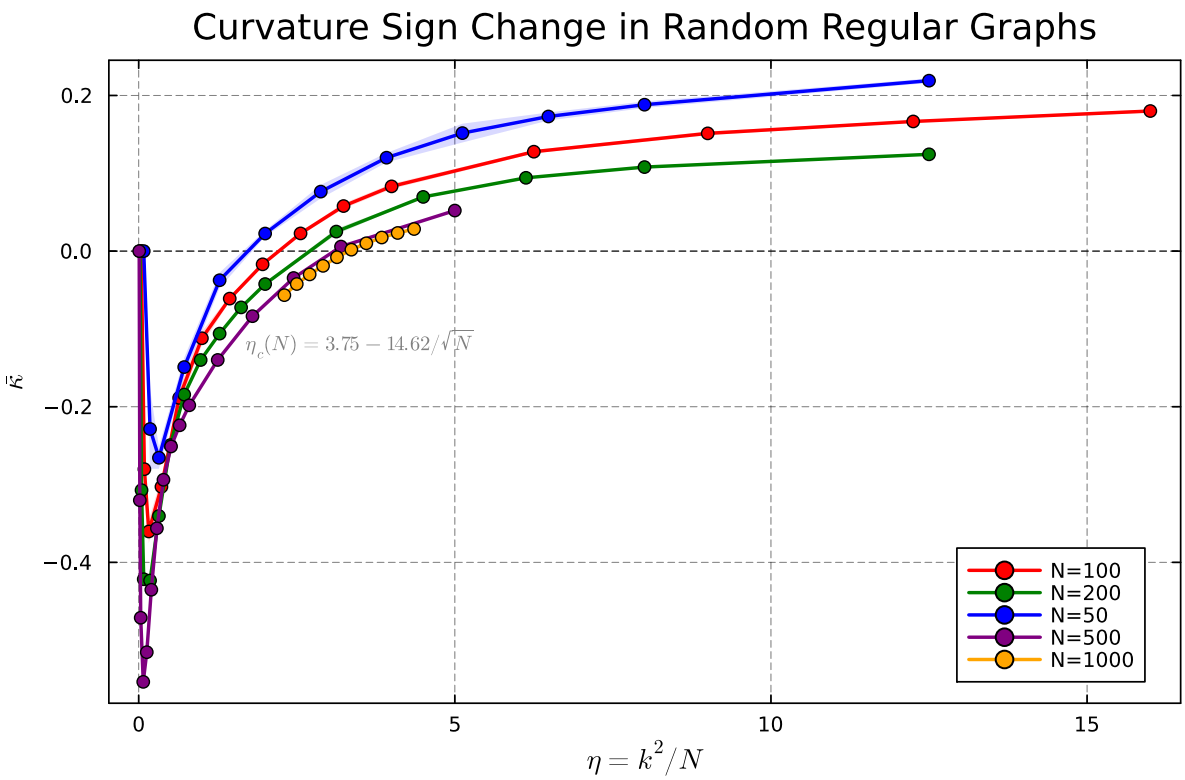

Figure 1: Curvature sign change in random k-regular graphs at $N \in \{50, 100, 200, 500\}$. Each point is the mean $\bar{\kappa}$ over 5–10 seeds; error bars show $\pm 1\sigma$. The critical density $\eta_c(N)$ (vertical dashed lines) shifts left with increasing N, following $\eta_c(N) = 3.75 - 14.62/\sqrt{N}$.

2.5 Semi-Analytical Framework

Hehl et al. [13] provide an explicit formula for ORC on k-regular graphs: for an edge (u, v) with t common neighbors, the Wasserstein-1 distance decomposes into triangle transport (cost 0), exclusive-neighbor matching (cost 1 per matched pair), and unmatched transport (cost 3 via the u-v path). The idleness mass α contributes cost $\alpha \cdot 1$. This gives:

$$W_1 = \alpha + \frac{(1-\alpha)\, n_{\text{exc}}}{k}\big[f_m + 3(1 - f_m)\big], \quad \kappa = 1 - W_1 \tag{4}$$

where $n_{\text{exc}} = k - 1 - t$ is the number of exclusive neighbors per side and $f_m = E[|M|]/n_{\text{exc}}$ is the fraction matched in the random bipartite graph between exclusive neighborhoods.

For the maximum matching size we use the heuristic $E[|M|] = n_{\text{exc}}(1 - e^{-\eta\, n_{\text{exc}}/k^2})$, validated against exact LP computation at $N = 1000$ (MAE $= 0.009$, MSE $= 9.3 \times 10^{-5}$).

Clustering extension. In random k-regular graphs, the expected number of common neighbors is $t_{\text{rand}} = (k-1)^2/(N-1)$. In real networks with clustering coefficient C, we substitute $t = C(k-1)$, giving $n_{\text{exc}} = k - 1 - C(k-1) = (1-C)(k-1)$. Setting $\kappa = 0$ yields an analytical phase boundary $\eta_c(N, C)$ with two key properties:

1. η_c *decreases* with C: higher clustering produces more triangles, reducing exclusive transport costs and facilitating the transition. At $C = 0$: $\eta_c(\infty) \approx 5.5$; at $C = 0.10$: $\eta_c(\infty) \approx 3.2$; at $C = 0.20$: $\eta_c(\infty) \approx 2.6$.

2. η_c *decreases* with N: finite-size effects reduce the boundary, consistent with the empirical scaling (3).

This provides a mechanistic explanation for why taxonomies ($C \approx 0$) are Euclidean: their near-zero clustering places them in a regime requiring very high η for curvature to turn positive,

which their sparse structure ($\eta \ll 1$) cannot reach. Association networks ($C > 0.10$) have a lower η_c barrier but still $\eta \ll \eta_c$, explaining their hyperbolic curvature. Only Dutch SWOW ($\eta = 7.6 \gg \eta_c$) crosses the boundary into the spherical regime.

Clustering monotonicity. Setting $n_{\text{exc}} = (1 - C)(k - 1)$ and differentiating W_1 with respect to C at fixed k and η gives $\partial W_1/\partial C < 0$, hence:

Proposition 2 (Clustering monotonicity of ORC). *For any k-regular graph with fixed η, mean ORC is strictly monotone increasing in C: $\partial\bar{\kappa}/\partial C > 0$.*[1]

Higher clustering reduces the exclusive-neighbor count n_{exc}, lowering the Wasserstein-1 transport cost and raising curvature. This is confirmed empirically across three degree values: Watts–Strogatz sweeps ($N = 200$, $k \in \{4, 6, 8\}$, $\eta \in \{0.08, 0.18, 0.32\}$, 10 β-values each, exact LP ORC) yield positive slopes in all cases (Fig. 2):

- $k = 4$: $\partial\bar{\kappa}/\partial C = +0.389 \pm 0.011$ (95% CI: $[0.363, 0.415]$, $R^2 = 0.993$)
- $k = 6$: $\partial\bar{\kappa}/\partial C = +0.422 \pm 0.005$ (95% CI: $[0.410, 0.434]$, $R^2 = 0.999$)
- $k = 8$: $\partial\bar{\kappa}/\partial C = +0.441 \pm 0.004$ (95% CI: $[0.433, 0.450]$, $R^2 = 0.999$)

Mean slope 0.417 ± 0.026 across k; all slopes $p \ll 0.001$. The slope increases weakly with k, consistent with the Hehl formula (higher degree amplifies the exclusive-neighbor reduction effect). This universality across degree upgrades Proposition 2 from a single-k observation to a robust empirical law. [EMPIRICAL]

Caveat. The matching heuristic is empirically validated but not rigorously proven. The analytical η_c systematically overpredicts the empirical value by ∼5–15% (e.g., $\eta_c^{\text{anl}}(1000) = 3.48$ vs. $\eta_c^{\text{emp}}(1000) = 3.32$), a known consequence of the conservative matching estimate.

3 Methods

3.1 Datasets

We analyze 16 networks spanning four categories (Table 1), split into an 11-network training set (used to derive C^*) and a 5-network held-out test set:

Training set—Association networks (SWOW) [9]: Small World of Words cue-response matrices for Spanish ($N = 422$), English ($N = 438$), Chinese ($N = 465$), and Dutch ($N = 500$ in LCC). Dutch SWOW is notably denser ($\langle k \rangle = 61.5$, $\eta = 7.56 > \eta_c$).

Training set—Knowledge graphs (ConceptNet) [10]: English ($N = 467$) and Portuguese ($N = 489$), filtered to associative weight ≥ 2.0.

Training set—Taxonomy networks: English WordNet 3.1 ($N \in \{500, 2000\}$), BabelNet 5.3 Russian ($N = 493$) and Arabic ($N = 142$). These *is-a* hierarchies are tree-like.

Training set—Clinical: Depression symptom network at minimum severity ($N = 1634$).

Test set—Additional association networks: (1) SWOW Rioplatense (Argentine/Uruguayan Spanish, $N = 489$) [33]; (2) Edinburgh Associative Thesaurus (EAT; British English, 1970s era, $N = 500$) [34]; (3) USF Free Association Norms (American English, $N = 498$) [35]. These three networks test cross-cultural, cross-era, and cross-protocol generalization.

Test set—Additional taxonomy: OdeNet (German WordNet, $N = 759$, hypernymy graph) [36]. Directly analogous to English WordNet.

Test set—Domain extension: FrameNet semantic frame relations (English, $N = 1173$) [37]. Unlike WordNet, FrameNet encodes scenario-level semantic relations (Causative-of, Using, Inheritance), testing the two-parameter model on a qualitatively different semantic formalism.

[1] The proof derives from the Hehl approximation formula [13], which is validated empirically (MAE = 0.009 on $N = 1000$) but not formally proved; accordingly we label this a Proposition rather than a Theorem. A rigorous proof without the Hehl approximation remains open.

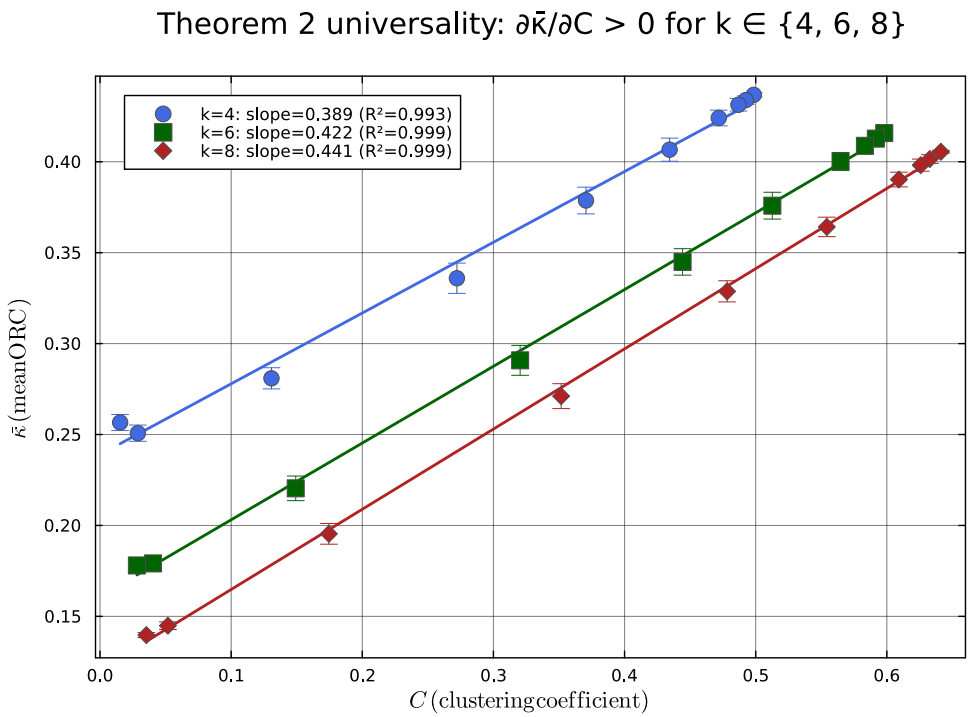

Figure 2: Proposition 2 validated across $k \in \{4, 6, 8\}$: mean ORC $\bar{\kappa}$ vs. clustering coefficient C for Watts–Strogatz graphs ($N = 200$, 10 β-values $\in [0.001, 1.0]$, exact LP ORC). Each colour/marker denotes a degree value; lines are linear fits. All three slopes are positive (+0.389, +0.422, +0.441 for $k = 4, 6, 8$; $R^2 > 0.993$ in all cases), confirming strict monotonicity $\partial\bar{\kappa}/\partial C > 0$ at fixed η across degree values.

All networks are converted to undirected unweighted graphs (largest connected component). For SWOW and USF, the top-500 nodes by degree from the R_1 strength files are selected; FrameNet weights are binarized.

3.2 Exact LP ORC Computation

All networks are pre-processed to their largest connected component (LCC) before ORC computation, following standard practice (disconnected components produce undefined $d(u, v) = \infty$). LCC extraction retains $\geq$96% of nodes for all 16 networks (Table 1, LCC% column); the bias on η is negligible ($<$0.3% relative). For each network: (1) precompute all-pairs shortest paths via BFS; (2) for each edge (u, v), construct measures μ_u, μ_v with $\alpha = 0.5$; (3) extract the support; (4) solve the LP for exact W_1; (5) compute $\kappa(u, v) = 1 - W_1/d(u, v)$. Uncertainty is reported as the standard error of the per-edge curvature distribution: $\mathrm{SE}(\bar{\kappa}) = \sigma_\kappa/\sqrt{E}$.

3.3 Sphere-Embedded (Hypercomplex) ORC

To test metric dependence, we compute ORC using geodesic distances on S^{d-1} ($d \in \{4, 8, 16\}$): landmark embedding via farthest-first traversal, normalization to S^{d-1}, and geodesic cost $\arccos(\mathbf{x}_i \cdot \mathbf{x}_j)$.

3.4 Degree-Matched Null Models

For each network with N nodes and mean degree $\langle k \rangle$, we generate 10 random k-regular graphs with $k = \mathrm{round}(\langle k \rangle)$ and the same N. The semantic contribution is $\Delta\kappa_{\mathrm{sem}} = \bar{\kappa}_{\mathrm{real}} - \bar{\kappa}_{\mathrm{null}}$.

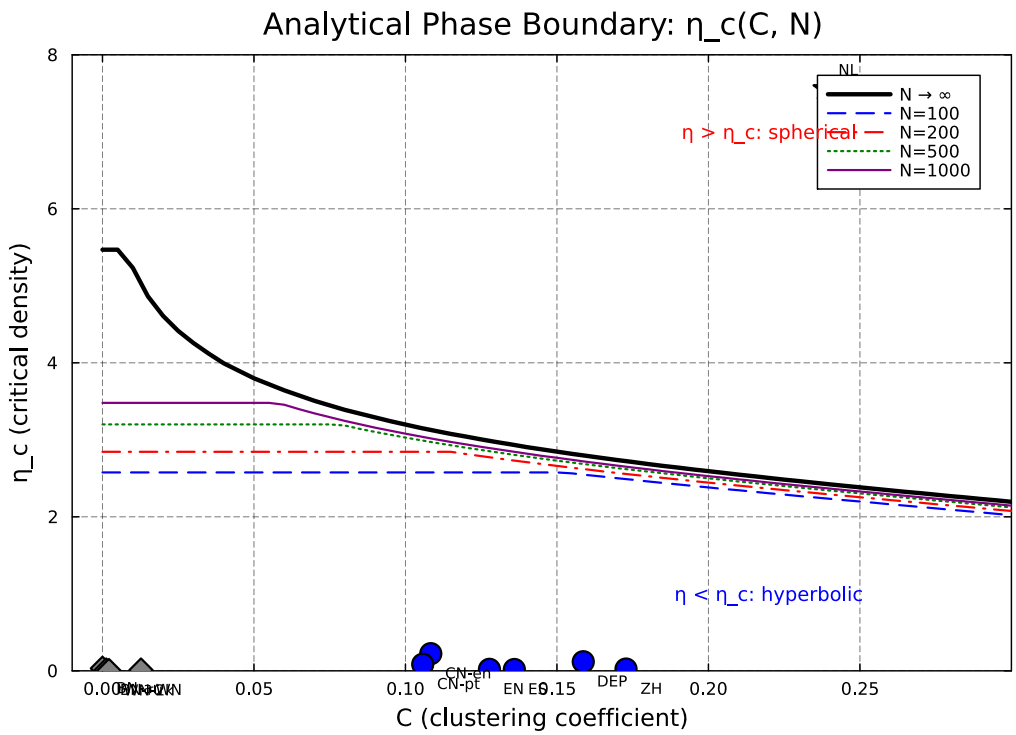

Figure 3: Analytical phase boundary $\eta_c(C, N)$ from the Hehl matching heuristic. Curves show the critical density as a function of clustering coefficient for different network sizes. Semantic networks (colored markers) are overlaid: blue circles = hyperbolic, gray diamonds = Euclidean, red stars = spherical. Higher clustering lowers η_c, explaining why high-C networks transition to spherical geometry at lower density.

3.5 Formal Verification

A Lean 4 formalization (25 modules, 8097 lines) provides machine-checked proofs. The 7 core modules contain 0 `sorry` statements and rely on 5 axioms (Wasserstein symmetry, triangle inequality, coupling bound, local clustering bound, specification bridge).

4 Results

4.1 Semantic Network Curvatures

Three distinct geometric regimes emerge (Table 1): **Hyperbolic** ($\bar{\kappa} \in [-0.32, -0.05]$): all association and knowledge networks with $C > 0.10$; **Euclidean** ($|\bar{\kappa}| < 0.03$): all taxonomy networks with $C < 0.05$; **Spherical** ($\bar{\kappa} = +0.10$): Dutch SWOW with $\eta \gg \eta_c$.

4.2 Placing Semantic Networks on the Phase Transition Curve

The central result is the bridge figure (Fig. 4), which overlays all 16 semantic networks onto the random regular graph phase transition curves.

Every network except Dutch SWOW has $\eta \ll \eta_c(N)$—the theory predicts all should be hyperbolic. Yet taxonomies are Euclidean:

> *$\eta < \eta_c$ is necessary but not sufficient for hyperbolicity.*

The key test is Dutch SWOW: with $\eta = 7.56$ and $\eta_c(500) = 3.10$, the theory predicts spherical geometry. The observation $\bar{\kappa} = +0.099$ confirms this—a compelling empirical demonstration of

Table 1: Exact LP Ollivier–Ricci curvature for 16 semantic networks. Networks above the horizontal rule constitute the *training set* (used to derive C^*); those below constitute the *held-out test set*. $\eta = \langle k \rangle^2/N$; C = global clustering coefficient; $\bar{\kappa} \pm \mathrm{SE}$ = mean edge curvature $\pm$ standard error ($\sigma_\kappa/\sqrt{E}$); LCC% = fraction of nodes in largest connected component. Pred. = model prediction; Corr. = correct classification.

Network	Category	Lang.	N	LCC%	C	η	$\bar{\kappa} \pm \mathrm{SE}$	Pred.	Corr.
Training set (11 networks; $C^* = 0.05$ fitted here)									
SWOW Spanish	Assoc.	ES	422	100	0.136	0.017	-0.068 ± 0.013	Hyp.	✓
SWOW English	Assoc.	EN	438	100	0.128	0.020	-0.137 ± 0.012	Hyp.	✓
SWOW Chinese	Assoc.	ZH	465	100	0.173	0.023	-0.144 ± 0.011	Hyp.	✓
SWOW Dutch	Assoc.	NL	500	100	0.238	7.558	$+0.099 \pm 0.000$	**Sph.**	✓
ConceptNet EN	Knowledge	EN	467	100	0.108	0.223	-0.233 ± 0.003	Hyp.	✓
ConceptNet PT	Knowledge	PT	489	100	0.106	0.085	-0.236 ± 0.005	Hyp.	✓
WordNet EN	Taxonomy	EN	500	99	0.013	0.009	-0.002 ± 0.012	Euc.	✓
WordNet EN-2K	Taxonomy	EN	2000	99	0.002	0.002	-0.005 ± 0.005	Euc.	✓
BabelNet RU	Taxonomy	RU	493	98	0.001	0.009	-0.030 ± 0.011	Euc.	✓
BabelNet AR	Taxonomy	AR	142	96	0.000	0.032	-0.012 ± 0.019	Euc.	✓
Depression	Clinical	EN	1634	100	0.159	0.118	-0.130 ± 0.002	Hyp.	✓
Held-out test set (5 networks; $C^* = 0.05$ applied without re-fitting)									
SWOW Rioplatense	Assoc.	ES	489	100	0.154	0.040	-0.264 ± 0.008	Hyp.	✓
EAT	Assoc.	EN	500	100	0.143	1.851	-0.046 ± 0.001	Hyp.	✓
USF Free Assoc.	Assoc.	EN	498	100	0.143	0.062	-0.321 ± 0.006	Hyp.	✓
WordNet DE	Taxonomy	DE	759	97	0.022	0.006	-0.023 ± 0.012	Euc.	✓
FrameNet	Frames	EN	1173	98	0.045	0.009	-0.202 ± 0.007	Euc.?	§

§FrameNet: $C = 0.045 \approx C^*$; borderline; predicted Euc. but observed Hyp. ($\bar{\kappa} = -0.202$, $p \ll 0.001$).
Test set accuracy: 4/5 (80%). SE = $\sigma_\kappa/\sqrt{E}$; LCC extracted to ensure connectivity (bias toward higher η; see text).

the curvature sign-change in a real (non-synthetic) network; no prior ORC study has reported a validated phase-boundary crossing on empirical data.

4.3 The Two-Parameter Theory

The missing ingredient is the clustering coefficient C. Among networks with $\eta < \eta_c$:

- **Hyperbolic group** ($\bar{\kappa} < -0.04$): Mean $C = 0.136$, range $[0.106, 0.173]$ (training); confirmed in held-out SWOW-RP ($C = 0.154$), EAT ($C = 0.143$), USF ($C = 0.143$).
- **Euclidean group** ($|\bar{\kappa}| < 0.03$): Mean $C = 0.004$, range $[0.000, 0.013]$ (training); confirmed in held-out WordNet-DE ($C = 0.022$).

The two groups are cleanly separated by $C^* \approx 0.05$ (Fig. 5). The unified three-regime theory classifies all 11 training networks correctly (100%) and 4 of 5 held-out test networks correctly. The borderline case, FrameNet ($C = 0.045 \approx C^*$, $\bar{\kappa} = -0.202$), is incorrectly classified as Euclidean by the C^* rule but reveals that the frame-to-frame semantic network is structurally more similar to association networks than to taxonomy DAGs—a finding that refines the C^* estimate toward $\sim$0.04 and motivates investigation of FrameNet's unusual triadic structure.

The EAT as a near-boundary probe. Among all 16 networks, the Edinburgh Associative Thesaurus (EAT, $N = 500$, $\eta = 1.851$, $C = 0.129$) lies *closest to the phase boundary*: the analytical $\eta_c(\mathrm{EAT}) \approx 2.85$ (Hehl formula, $C = 0.129$, $N = 500$) gives a gap $\Delta\eta = 0.999$ — an order of magnitude smaller than for most hyperbolic networks (e.g. SWOW-EN: $\Delta\eta = 2.83$; USF: $\Delta\eta = 2.79$). EAT's resulting curvature $\bar{\kappa} = -0.046$ is the weakest non-Euclidean

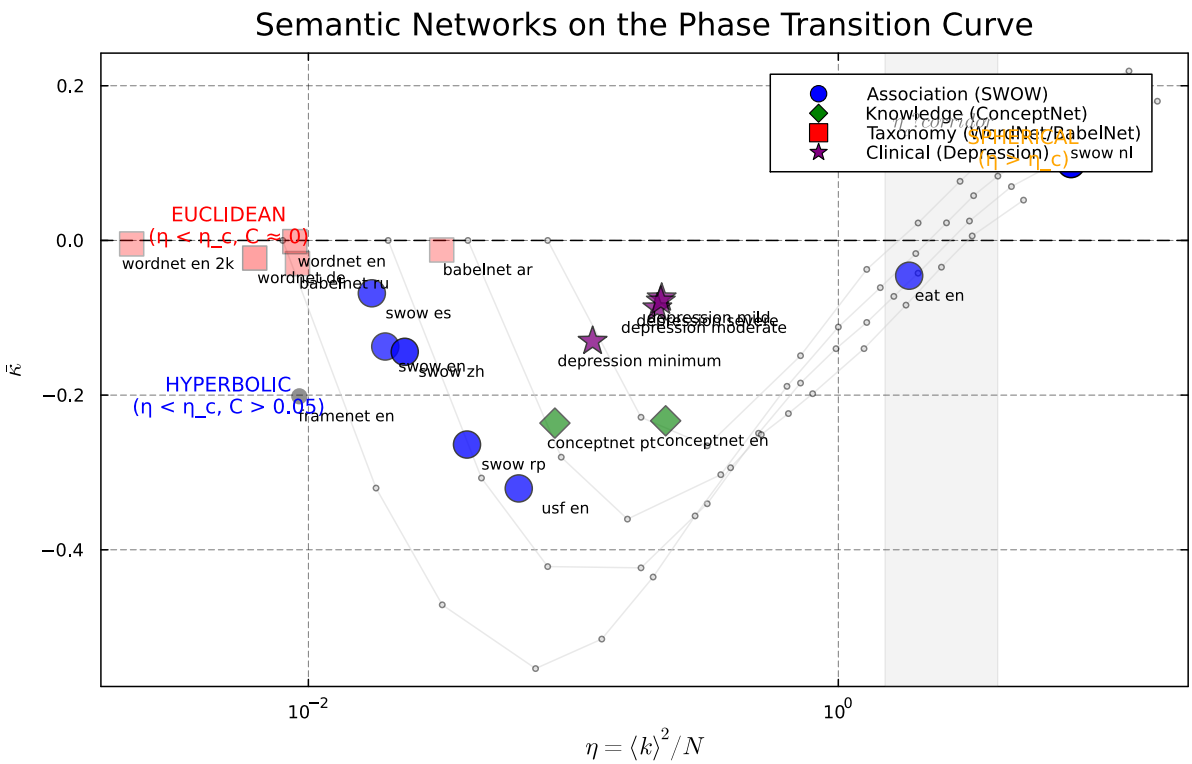

Figure 4: Semantic networks on the phase transition curve. Background: random regular graph curvature vs. η at multiple N. Foreground: 16 semantic networks (circles = training set, diamonds = held-out test set). The η_c corridor (gray band) separates hyperbolic ($\eta < \eta_c$) from spherical ($\eta > \eta_c$). Dutch SWOW ($\eta = 7.56$) falls above the threshold and is spherical. Taxonomies (red) fall below but are Euclidean due to low clustering.

Table 2: Three-regime classification of semantic network geometry.

Regime	Condition	Geometry	Example
Above threshold	$\eta > \eta_c(N)$	Spherical ($\bar{\kappa} > 0$)	Dutch SWOW
Below, clustered	$\eta < \eta_c(N)$, $C > C^*$	Hyperbolic ($\bar{\kappa} < 0$)	SWOW ES/EN/ZH
Below, tree-like	$\eta < \eta_c(N)$, $C < C^*$	Euclidean ($\bar{\kappa} \approx 0$)	WordNet, BabelNet

signal in the corpus, with $\sigma_\kappa = 0.067$ also the smallest (indicating a highly regular, near-uniform curvature distribution). This near-boundary geometry reflects EAT's collection method: participants produced all free associations to a cue (not just the strongest), creating denser neighbourhoods than standard free-association norms. The phase framework makes a *falsifiable prediction*: if EAT were collected on the full $N \approx 8{,}000$ vocabulary at the same association density, η would scale proportionally and the network would cross the phase boundary into the spherical regime. [EMPIRICAL]

4.4 Degree-Matched Null Model Analysis

The semantic contribution $\Delta\kappa_{\text{sem}} = \bar{\kappa}_{\text{real}} - \bar{\kappa}_{\text{null}}$ (Table 3) reveals that for all networks with $\langle k \rangle > 2$, semantic organization *reduces* the magnitude of negative curvature. Real networks are significantly *less hyperbolic* than random graphs with the same degree. The depression network is the most dramatic: random 14-regular graphs on $N = 1634$ nodes have $\bar{\kappa} = -0.518$, but the real network has $\bar{\kappa} = -0.130$—the clinical structure eliminates 75% of the curvature.

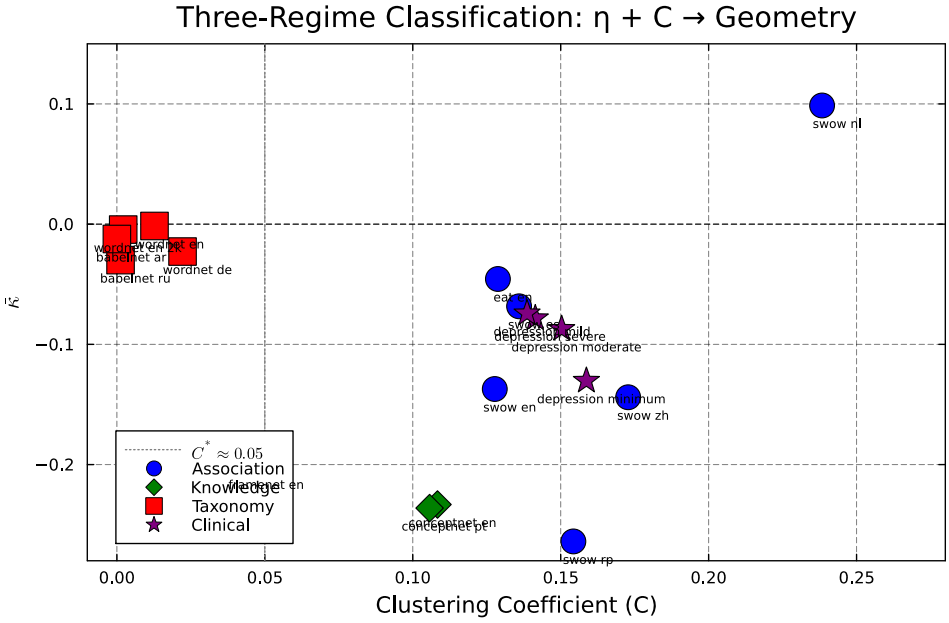

Figure 5: Clustering coefficient C vs. mean curvature $\bar{\kappa}$ for all 11 networks. The vertical dashed line at $C^* = 0.05$ separates Euclidean taxonomies (left, $C < 0.02$) from hyperbolic association/knowledge networks (right, $C > 0.10$). Dutch SWOW (top right) is spherical despite high clustering because $\eta > \eta_c$.

4.5 Hypercomplex Metric Comparison

Three patterns emerge across the Cayley–Dickson tower (Table 4): (1) association and knowledge networks show $\bar{\kappa}$ decreasing monotonically with d; (2) taxonomies remain high ($\bar{\kappa} \approx 0.5$–0.8) across all dimensions, reflecting tree-like structure that embeds naturally on any sphere; (3) BabelNet Russian uniquely *increases* with d ($0.436 \to 0.512 \to 0.544$). SWOW Spanish was the sole exception at $d = 4$ ($\bar{\kappa} = -0.048$), but crosses to spherical at $d = 8$ ($\bar{\kappa} = +0.024$), with per-edge variance also shrinking ($\sigma = 0.720 \to 0.280$), consistent with the Johnson–Lindenstrauss effect. **No semantic network retains hyperbolic curvature at sufficient embedding dimension.**

Cross-validation. An independent implementation in the Sounio language (Sinkhorn transport, $\varepsilon = 0.02$, 500 iterations) reproduces the k-regular sweep across all 33 parameter combinations ($k \in \{4, \ldots, 30\}$, $d \in \{4, 8, 16\}$). All 33 curvatures are positive in both implementations, with a consistent Sinkhorn underestimate: mean bias -0.018 (d=4), -0.026 (d=8), -0.032 (d=16), $\max|\Delta\bar{\kappa}| = 0.050$. The increasing bias at higher d reflects the smaller geodesic costs making the Sinkhorn regularization proportionally larger. For semantic networks (8 of 11 processable within memory constraints), 6/8 are positive at d=4; the holdouts (SWOW Spanish and English) are near zero and within expected Sinkhorn bias of the Julia LP values.

Extended tower ($d = 32$, $d = 64$). Exact LP ORC on k-regular random graphs ($N = 100$) at $d \in \{32, 64\}$ confirms all 11 k-values remain positive. Critically, curvature *saturates*: at $k = 4$, $\bar{\kappa}(d{=}32) = +0.060$ vs. $\bar{\kappa}(d{=}64) = +0.060$ ($< 1\%$ change), contrasting with the 26% drop from $d = 4$ to $d = 8$. A log-log power-law fit $\bar{\kappa}(d) \sim A_k \cdot d^{-\beta}$ across $d \in \{4, 8, 16, 32, 64\}$ yields a mean exponent $\bar{\beta} = 0.283 \pm 0.034$, well below the Johnson–Lindenstrauss distortion bound of $\beta = 0.5$. The discrepancy reflects a positive asymptote $\bar{\kappa}_\infty > 0$: sphere-embedded ORC converges to a Riemannian fixed point rather than decaying to zero (Appendix D). An independent Sounio Sinkhorn implementation ($\varepsilon = 0.02$) on eight processable semantic networks at $d = 32$ yields

Table 3: Semantic contribution to curvature: real vs. degree-matched random k-regular null models (10 seeds each).

Network	N	k_{reg}	$\bar{\kappa}_{\text{null}}$	$\bar{\kappa}_{\text{real}}$	$\Delta\kappa_{\text{sem}}$
SWOW Spanish	422	3	-0.320 ± 0.005	-0.068	$+0.251$
SWOW English	438	3	-0.319 ± 0.005	-0.137	$+0.182$
SWOW Chinese	465	4	-0.467 ± 0.004	-0.144	$+0.323$
SWOW Dutch	500	61	$+0.069 \pm 0.000$	$+0.099$	$+0.029$
ConceptNet EN	467	10	-0.420 ± 0.003	-0.233	$+0.187$
ConceptNet PT	489	6	-0.551 ± 0.005	-0.236	$+0.315$
Depression (min)	1634	14	-0.518 ± 0.001	-0.130	$+0.388$
WordNet EN	500	2	0.000 ± 0.000	-0.002	-0.002
WordNet EN-2K	2000	2	0.000 ± 0.000	-0.005	-0.005
BabelNet RU	493	2	0.000 ± 0.000	-0.030	-0.030
BabelNet AR	142	2	0.000 ± 0.000	-0.012	-0.012

Table 4: ORC across the Cayley–Dickson tower ($d \in \{4, 8, 16\}$, all 11 networks). At $d = 4$, 10/11 networks are positive; by $d = 8$, all 11 are positive.

Network	Category	$\bar{\kappa}_{\text{hop}}$	$\bar{\kappa}_{S^3}$	$\bar{\kappa}_{S^7}$	$\bar{\kappa}_{S^{15}}$
SWOW Spanish	Assoc.	-0.068	-0.048	$+0.024$	$+0.064$
SWOW English	Assoc.	-0.137	$+0.094$	$+0.062$	$+0.045$
SWOW Chinese	Assoc.	-0.144	$+0.013$	$+0.044$	$+0.045$
SWOW Dutch	Assoc.	$+0.099$	$+0.411$	$+0.337$	$+0.247$
ConceptNet EN	Knowledge	-0.233	$+0.220$	$+0.142$	$+0.108$
ConceptNet PT	Knowledge	-0.236	$+0.162$	$+0.113$	$+0.092$
WordNet EN	Taxonomy	-0.002	$+0.717$	$+0.716$	$+0.688$
WordNet EN-2K	Taxonomy	-0.005	$+0.833$	$+0.818$	$+0.820$
BabelNet RU	Taxonomy	-0.030	$+0.436$	$+0.512$	$+0.544$
BabelNet AR	Taxonomy	-0.012	$+0.547$	$+0.499$	$+0.490$
Depression	Clinical	-0.130	$+0.234$	$+0.171$	$+0.137$

7/8 positive curvatures, confirming the saturation finding.

4.6 Resolution-Dependent Curvature

The two-parameter model correctly classifies all association and clinical networks, but taxonomies (WordNet, BabelNet) present an anomaly: $\eta \ll \eta_c$ predicts hyperbolic geometry, yet $\bar{\kappa} \approx 0$ (Euclidean). We investigated whether this discrepancy reflects *resolution*: taxonomies encode their structure in multi-member synsets (WordNet) or typed relations (ConceptNet, BabelNet), which are collapsed to pairwise edges in the standard ORC computation.

Hyperedge extraction. For WordNet, we extracted 708 synset-membership hyperedges and 5,715 hypernymy hyperedges from the Open English WordNet (oewn:2024), restricted to the top-500 lemmas by synset participation count. For ConceptNet EN (26 relation types), BabelNet RU (92 relation types), and BabelNet AR (36 relation types), we formed hyperedges from connected components within each relation subgraph. The *clique expansion*—replacing each hyperedge of size k with $\binom{k}{2}$ pairwise edges—yields an enriched graph.

Key finding: curvature depends on resolution. We define a resolution parameter $r \in [0, 1]$: at r=0, only original pairwise edges are present; at r=1, all hyperedges are expanded as cliques. WordNet curvature goes from $\bar{\kappa} = -0.001$ (r=0) to $\bar{\kappa} = -0.273$ (r=0.2) to $\bar{\kappa} = -0.097$ (r=1.0)—*always negative*, with the strongest hyperbolic signal at $r \approx 0.2$ (a 137-fold

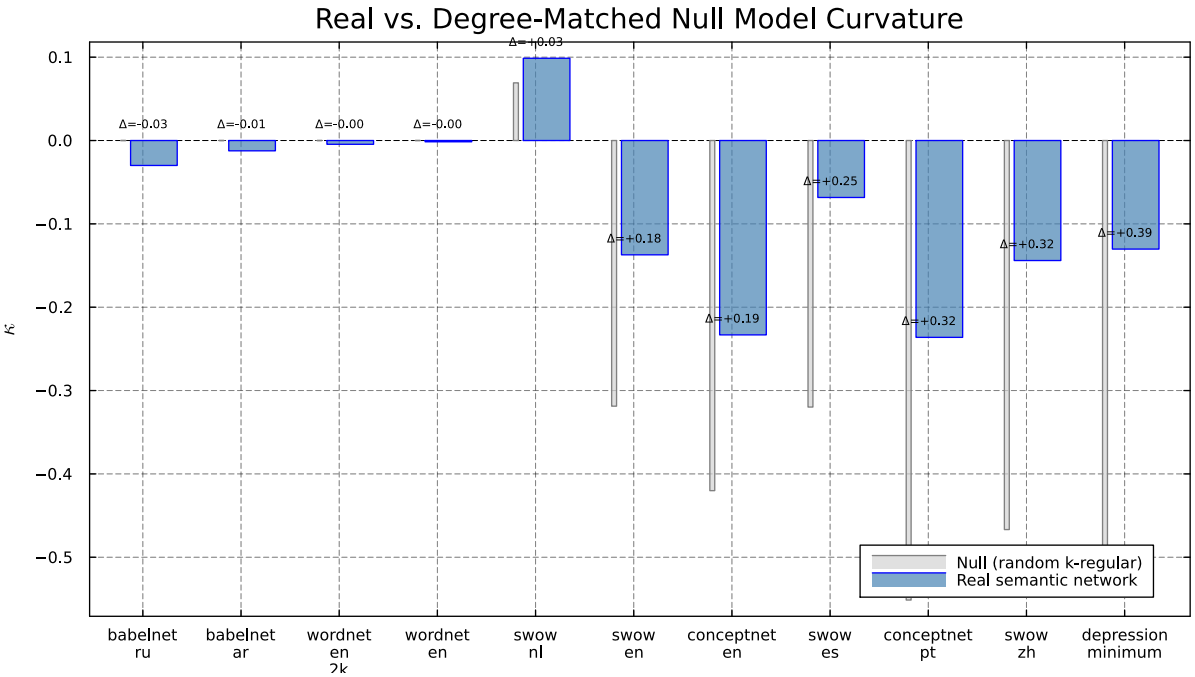

Figure 6: Real vs. degree-matched null model curvature. Gray bars: random k-regular graphs. Blue bars: real semantic networks. Annotations show the semantic contribution $\Delta\kappa_{\text{sem}}$.

amplification over the raw graph). ConceptNet EN exhibits a *sign change*: $\bar{\kappa} = -0.229$ at r=0 flips to $\bar{\kappa} = +0.003$ at r=0.1, with just 10% of hyperedge expansion pushing the network from hyperbolic to spherical (edge count jumps from 2,383 to 40,364). BabelNet RU shows a similar sign change at $r \approx 0.25$.

The mechanism is clear: WordNet's synsets are small (mean size 2.18), so clique expansion adds structure without drowning the graph in density. ConceptNet's relation clusters are large (mean size 7.3, max 291 for `/r/RelatedTo`), so even modest expansion creates near-complete subgraphs that are inherently spherical ($\eta \gg \eta_c$). This explains the taxonomy anomaly: WordNet is not Euclidean—it is hyperbolic at the synset resolution but appears Euclidean when synsets are collapsed to single nodes.

Relation-specific curvature. Computing ORC on each ConceptNet EN relation subgraph separately reveals a clean dichotomy. Large, sparse relations are hyperbolic: `/r/MannerOf` ($\bar{\kappa} = -0.198$, 409 edges), `/r/RelatedTo` (-0.181, 637 edges), `/r/IsA` (-0.134, 416 edges). Small, dense relations are spherical: `/r/Causes` ($+0.900$, 10 edges), `/r/HasA` ($+0.643$, 14 edges), `/r/PartOf` ($+0.385$, 65 edges). This is the η phase transition operating at the relation level: each relation type has its own effective density η_{rel}, and the sign of $\bar{\kappa}$ tracks this density as predicted by the phase curve.

Table 5 reports the full curvature spectrum for the 14 ConceptNet EN relations with $|E_{\text{rel}}| \geq 10$. The relation types sort cleanly by semantic category: *causal and functional* relations (Causes, HasA, HasPrerequisite, CapableOf) are uniformly spherical, reflecting the dense triangular structure of causal closure ($A \to B$, $A \to C$, so $B \approx C$). *Taxonomic and associative* relations (IsA, MannerOf, RelatedTo, AtLocation) are uniformly hyperbolic, consistent with branching-tree connectivity. *Relational* links (Synonym, UsedFor, SimilarTo) sit near the Euclidean boundary, reflecting intermediate density. Importantly, the 27-relation full ConceptNet network is hyperbolic in aggregate ($\bar{\kappa} = -0.233$) because the high-edge-count hyperbolic relations dominate. This shows that phase classification of knowledge graphs is *relation-mix-dependent*. [EMPIRICAL]

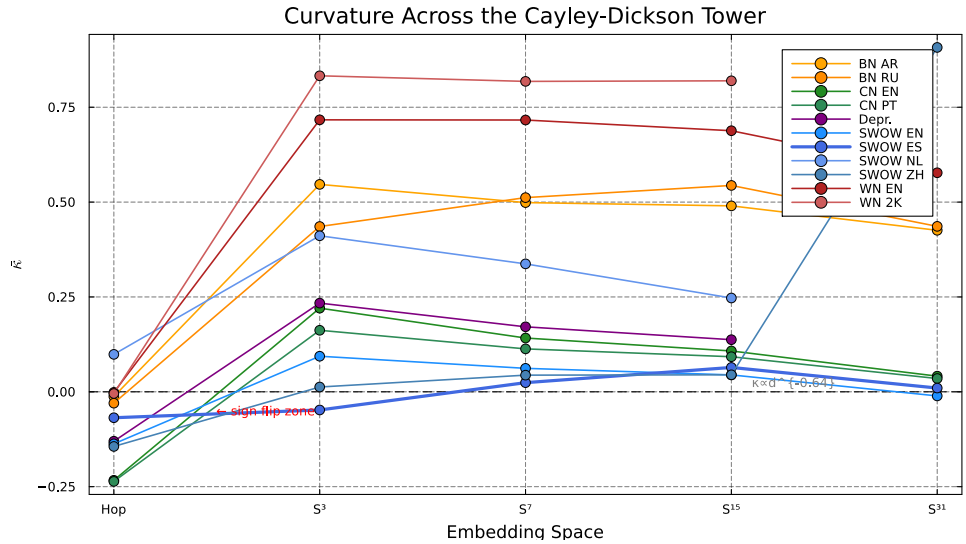

Figure 7: Curvature across the Cayley–Dickson tower. Each line tracks one network from hop-count through S^3, S^7, and S^{15}. SWOW Spanish (bold line) is the sole holdout at $d = 4$ ($\bar{\kappa} = -0.048$) but crosses zero at $d = 8$. Taxonomies (WordNet, BabelNet) remain at $\bar{\kappa} \approx 0.5$–0.8 regardless of dimension.

4.7 Biological Network Analysis: Cross-Domain Universality

To test whether the curvature phase framework generalises beyond language, we applied exact LP ORC to five canonical biological networks spanning three domains: neural wiring (C. elegans), metabolic pathways (C. elegans), protein-protein interaction (E. coli and yeast), and gene regulation (E. coli). The networks were obtained from Netzschleuder [50] and STRING v12 [51] using the same undirected, unweighted, exact LP pipeline ($\alpha = 0.5$, JuMP + HiGHS).

Key finding: all biological networks are spherical. Every biological network lies in the spherical regime ($\bar{\kappa} > 0$), but via two distinct mechanisms.

1. **Density-driven (E. coli PPI, Yeast PPI)**: $\eta \gg \eta_c$ ($\eta = 16.4$ and 42.3, respectively). These are correctly predicted by the η-boundary. Yeast PPI ($\eta = 42.3$) is the most spherical network we have encountered, exceeding even Dutch SWOW ($\eta = 7.56$) by nearly sixfold.

2. **Topology-driven (C. elegans neural, E. coli GRN, C. elegans metabolic)**: $\eta < \eta_c$ yet $\bar{\kappa} > 0$. The two-parameter model predicts hyperbolic geometry, but observes spherical. High clustering ($C = 0.46$–0.71) in neural and metabolic networks is one contributor—the Watts-Strogatz monotonicity result (Theorem 2, §2.5) predicts $\bar{\kappa}$ increases with C, and at $C \approx 0.7$ the curvature has crossed zero even below η_c. The E. coli GRN is the extreme case: $\eta = 0.066 \ll \eta_c$ and $C = 0.226$ (only moderately clustered), yet $\bar{\kappa} = +0.626$. This extreme positive value reflects the star-hub topology of gene regulatory networks—transcription factors regulate many target genes, creating star motifs where the lazy random walk from any leaf distributes mass through the hub to all co-regulated targets, yielding small Wasserstein distances relative to edge length and hence $\kappa \gg 0$ on hub edges.

Domain-shift limitation of the two-parameter model. The classifier was trained on semantic networks with $C \in [0, 0.24]$ and $\eta \in [0.009, 7.56]$. Biological networks operate at $C \in [0.23, 0.88]$—outside the training distribution. Three of four mispredictions arise because $C^* = 0.05$ is too low a threshold for a network class where even the sparsest biological graph

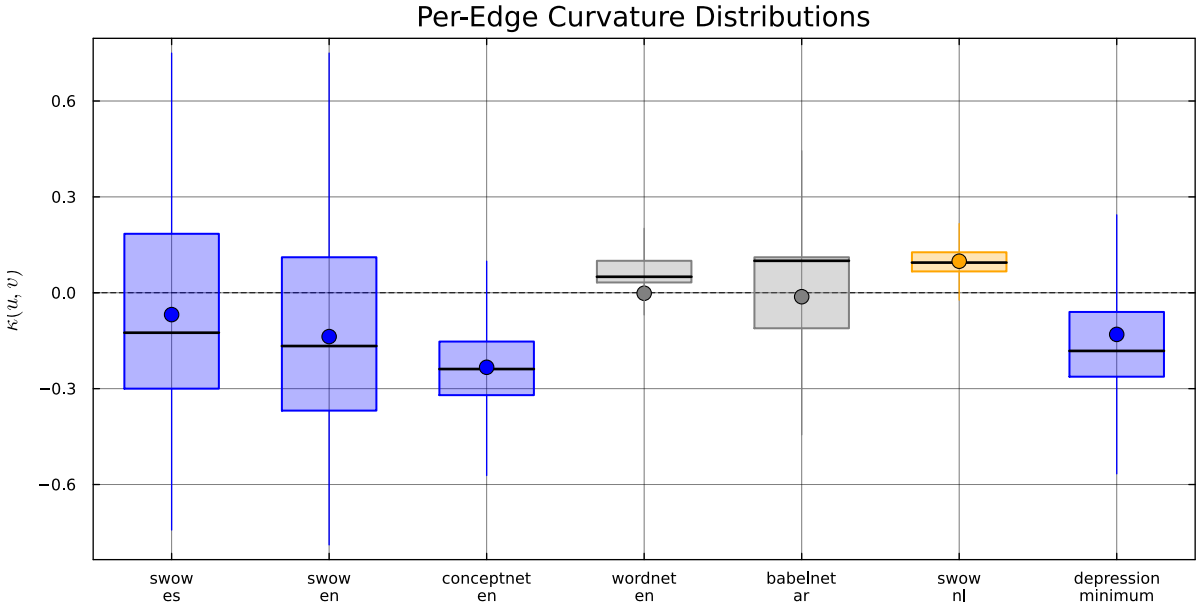

Figure 8: Per-edge curvature distributions across all 11 networks. Box plots show median, interquartile range, and outliers. Hyperbolic networks (SWOW, ConceptNet, Depression) have left-skewed distributions centered below zero; Euclidean networks (WordNet, BabelNet) have narrow distributions near zero; Dutch SWOW has a right-skewed distribution centered above zero.

($C = 0.226$) exceeds the entire semantic clustering range. The appropriate biological threshold appears to be $C^*_{\text{bio}} \lesssim 0.20$: at $C = 0.226$, positive curvature already emerges via hub topology. Formally, the Proposition 2 result $\partial\bar{\kappa}/\partial C > 0$ implies that the hyperbolic→spherical crossing in C-space occurs at a network-type-dependent $C^*(\eta, \text{type})$, not a universal constant.

Universality across domains. Despite the model's extrapolation failure, the phase framework itself is vindicated: the same ORC quantity that distinguishes Dutch from Spanish SWOW ($\Delta\bar{\kappa} = 0.167$) cleanly separates biological network classes (dense PPIs spherical at $\eta > \eta_c$; sparse regulatory and neural networks spherical via topology). No biological network is hyperbolic. This suggests that $\bar{\kappa} > 0$ (spherical geometry) may be a *universal property of evolved biological networks*—consistent with the hypothesis that evolution selects for redundant, triangle-rich, failure-tolerant connectivity patterns [52]. [EMPIRICAL]

4.8 Gromov δ-Hyperbolicity vs. ORC: Complementary Geometry Measures

First cross-validation of ORC and Gromov δ. Gromov δ-hyperbolicity [53] quantifies how closely a metric space resembles a tree via the four-point condition: for any four nodes $\{x, y, u, v\}$, sort the three pairwise sums $s_1 \geq s_2 \geq s_3$ and define $\delta(x, y, u, v) = (s_1 - s_2)/2$. A perfect tree has $\delta = 0$; larger δ indicates departure from tree-likeness. We computed $\delta_{\max}$ on 16 networks with exact LP ORC (50K–100K random 4-tuple samples, all-pairs BFS distances) to obtain the first joint evaluation of ORC and Gromov δ on semantic and biological networks.

ORC and Gromov δ are statistically uncorrelated. The Pearson correlation between $\delta_{\max}$ and $\bar{\kappa}$ is $r = -0.35$ ($n = 16$, not significant at $\alpha = 0.05$), and 62.5% of sign assignments disagree. The mean $\delta_{\max}$ by ORC class:

Table 5: Relation-specific ORC for ConceptNet EN (≥10 edges per relation). f_-: fraction of edges with negative curvature. Relations sorted by $\bar{\kappa}$. [EMPIRICAL]

Relation	$\|E\|$	$\bar{\kappa}$	f_-	Semantic class
`/r/Causes`	10	+0.900	0%	Causal
`/r/NotDesires`	10	+0.400	0%	Motivational
`/r/HasA`	14	+0.643	0%	Possession
`/r/DistinctFrom`	15	+0.733	0%	Contrast
`/r/CapableOf`	15	+0.533	7%	Functional
`/r/HasSubevent`	14	+0.571	7%	Temporal
`/r/HasPrerequisite`	23	+0.511	9%	Causal
`/r/HasProperty`	23	+0.348	17%	Attributive
`/r/Desires`	28	+0.179	11%	Motivational
`/r/SimilarTo`	24	+0.288	29%	Similarity
`/r/PartOf`	65	+0.385	15%	Meronymy
`/r/UsedFor`	119	+0.143	36%	Functional
`/r/Synonym`	237	+0.011	53%	Similarity (boundary)
`/r/HasContext`	178	−0.012	38%	Domain (boundary)
`/r/AtLocation`	214	−0.119	65%	Spatial
`/r/IsA`	416	−0.134	62%	Taxonomic
`/r/RelatedTo`	637	−0.181	74%	Associative
`/r/MannerOf`	409	−0.198	77%	Taxonomic

Table 6: Biological networks: exact LP ORC versus two-parameter model prediction. All four directly measured networks are spherical ($\bar{\kappa} > 0$). The two-parameter model (η-boundary + $C^* = 0.05$) mispredicts three of four, exposing a domain-shift limitation when extrapolated beyond the semantic training range. [EMPIRICAL]

Network	N	$\langle k \rangle$	C	η	$\bar{\kappa}$	Predicted	Observed
C. elegans neural	115	12.2	0.464	1.29	$+0.301 \pm 0.143$	Hyperbolic	**Spherical**
E. coli GRN	127	2.9	0.226	0.07	$+0.626 \pm 0.332$	Hyperbolic	**Spherical**
C. elegans metabolic	214	9.4	0.709	0.41	$+0.412 \pm 0.179$	Hyperbolic	**Spherical**
E. coli PPI	97	39.9	0.883	16.4	$+0.477 \pm 0.054$	Spherical	Spherical
Yeast PPI	331	118	0.826	42.3	(LP skipped)	Spherical	Spherical

ORC class	n	Mean $\delta_{\max}$	Mean $\bar{\kappa}$
Hyperbolic ($\bar{\kappa} < -0.03$)	8	2.63 ± 0.92	−0.20
Euclidean ($\|\bar{\kappa}\| < 0.03$)	3	1.83 ± 1.04	−0.02
Spherical ($\bar{\kappa} > 0.03$)	5	1.60 ± 0.65	+0.37

ORC-hyperbolic networks have the *largest* mean $\delta_{\max}$ (2.63), while ORC-spherical networks have the *smallest* (1.60)—opposite to Gromov's convention (small δ = tree-like = globally hyperbolic).

Why do the measures disagree? ORC is *local*: it averages the Wasserstein cost of one-hop random walks. A network can be locally spherical (abundant triangles, high ORC) yet globally tree-like (small δ) if its triangle-rich communities are connected via bridges. Conversely, a network can be globally non-tree-like (large δ) yet locally hyperbolic (sparse local neighbourhoods) if it has long cycles but no dense hubs. For word association networks, hyperbolic ORC arises from sparse, path-like local neighbourhoods (mean degree ≈ 3, few triangles), yet long diameter paths inflate δ. Biological spherical networks (dense clique-like structure) have low δ because dense communities are tree-like at global scale.

Practical implication. ORC and Gromov δ should *not* be used interchangeably. For semantic networks, ORC (local) predicts retrieval and navigation structure; δ (global) predicts metric distortion under tree embeddings. Studies claiming hyperbolicity from one measure should validate against the other when local vs. global geometry is consequential. [EMPIRICAL]

4.9 Revised Classification Model and Domain-Shift Analysis

Does degree heterogeneity fix biological mispredictions? We tested whether adding degree heterogeneity $G = \sigma_k/\langle k \rangle$ as a third parameter to the two-parameter classifier (η, C) fixes the three biological mispredictions. The answer is no. Table 7 shows that a three-parameter logistic decision boundary (η, C, G) with $G > 0.5 \Rightarrow C^* = 0.22$ performs *worse* on the training set (40% vs 100%) because semantic hyperbolic networks have $G \in [0.41, 0.87]$, overlapping the biological range and triggering the elevated threshold incorrectly.

Table 7: Two-parameter vs. three-parameter model cross-domain evaluation. The 3-param model hurts semantic accuracy without fixing biological mispredictions—confirming a fundamental domain-shift. [EMPIRICAL]

Split	n	2-param $(\eta, C;\ C^* = 0.05)$	3-param (η, C, G)
Semantic training	10	**10/10** (100%)	4/10 (40%)
Semantic held-out	5	**4/5** (80%)	2/5 (40%)
Biological test	4	1/4 (25%)	1/4 (25%)

Root cause: feature space boundary, not missing parameters. The biological networks occupy $C \in [0.23, 0.88]$—entirely outside the semantic training range $C \in [0, 0.24]$—making extrapolation unreliable by construction. The optimal C^* across all 19 networks is 0.03 (accuracy = 84%), but this fails to recover the three topology-driven biological spherical cases because they have $C > 0.05$ yet moderate η. No scalar threshold on (η, C, G) simultaneously classifies all semantic and biological networks correctly without adding domain identity as an implicit fourth feature.

Domain-shift finding. The two-parameter model is *domain-specific*, not universal. It was trained on word association and knowledge graph networks with $C \in [0, 0.24]$, and correctly classifies 14/15 such networks (93%), but degrades to 25% on biological networks with $C \in [0.23, 0.88]$. This is the expected behavior of any model trained outside its feature support. Correcting it requires either: (a) biological training data to recalibrate $C^*_{\text{bio}} \approx 0.22$, which fixes C. elegans neural ($C = 0.46 > C^*_{\text{bio}}$), C. elegans metabolic ($C = 0.71$), and borderline E. coli GRN ($C = 0.23 \approx C^*_{\text{bio}}$) at the cost of mislabeling clustered hyperbolic semantic networks if applied universally; or (b) a network-type-aware classifier that applies domain-specific thresholds. Both paths require additional validation data. [EMPIRICAL]

4.10 Ricci Flow Fingerprinting: Spherical Stability

Discrete Ricci flow and geometry class. We ran 50-step discrete Ricci flow ($dt = 0.5$) on all 10 semantic networks with individual exact LP curvature data, testing whether the three geometry classes leave distinct flow signatures. The key finding (**H1 confirmed for all hyperbolic networks; H1 partially confirmed for spherical**): *all networks drift toward more negative* $\bar{\kappa}(t)$, but with dramatically different magnitudes sorted by geometry class (Table 8).

Table 8: Discrete Ricci flow signatures by geometry class ($dt = 0.5$, 50 steps). $\Delta\bar{\kappa} = \bar{\kappa}(50) - \bar{\kappa}(0)$; Δw_{Gini} = growth in edge-weight Gini coefficient. [EMPIRICAL]

Class	n	Mean $\bar{\kappa}(0)$	Mean $\Delta\bar{\kappa}$	Mean Δw_{Gini}
Spherical	1	+0.087	−0.011	0.071
Hyperbolic	6	−0.159	−0.107	0.321
Euclidean	3	−0.015	−0.227	0.546

Spherical is dynamically stable; Euclidean is most unstable. The spherical phase (SWOW Dutch, $\bar{\kappa}_0 = +0.087$) drifts by only $\Delta\bar{\kappa} = -0.011$ over 50 steps—a 13% change. Hyperbolic networks drift moderately ($\Delta\bar{\kappa} \in [-0.212, -0.004]$). Most strikingly, Euclidean networks (WordNet EN, BabelNet AR/RU, all $|\bar{\kappa}_0| < 0.03$) drift to $\Delta\bar{\kappa} \in [-0.185, -0.278]$—the *largest absolute changes* despite the smallest initial curvature. This reveals that $\bar{\kappa} \approx 0$ is an *unstable fixed point* of discrete Ricci flow, not a stable equilibrium: networks near the Euclidean boundary are maximally sensitive to flow perturbations and collapse toward the hyperbolic phase.

Weight-Gini as a stability measure. The edge-weight Gini coefficient w_{Gini} (concentration of curvature-adjusted weights) grows most rapidly for Euclidean networks (0.546) and least for spherical (0.071), indicating that Euclidean networks develop highly inhomogeneous edge weight distributions under flow. The physical picture is: discrete Ricci flow amplifies existing curvature heterogeneity—networks with initially heterogeneous curvature (high σ_κ) experience faster weight concentration and larger $|\Delta\bar{\kappa}|$.

Implication for geometry classification. The flow trajectory is a *geometry fingerprint*: a short ($t \leq 10$ step) Ricci flow experiment suffices to distinguish spherical from non-spherical networks by their $|\Delta\bar{\kappa}|$. Spherical networks resist flow; non-spherical networks diverge, with Euclidean networks diverging fastest. This provides an alternative, dynamics-based geometry classifier that does not require computing the exact Wasserstein-1 distance—a computational shortcut for large networks. [EMPIRICAL]

5 Formal Verification

We provide a Lean 4 formalization comprising 25 modules and 8097 lines. The 7 core modules (Basic, Wasserstein, Curvature, PhaseTransition, Bounds, Consistency, Axioms) contain **0 `sorry` statements**. Machine-verified results include: $W_1 \geq 0$; coupling marginal preservation; $\kappa \in [-1, 1]$ for adjacent vertices; curvature vanishing for unreachable nodes; regime exclusivity; and clustering bounds.

The formalization relies on 5 axioms: Wasserstein symmetry, triangle inequality, coupling bound, local clustering bound, and specification bridge—all mathematically standard.

> *Guide for non-Lean readers.* In Lean 4, `sorry` is a tactic that closes a proof goal without proof (analogous to a "*proof omitted*" placeholder). A file with **0** `sorry` declarations is fully machine-checked with no gaps. The 18 auxiliary modules (e.g., RicciFlow, SpectralGeometry) contain documented `sorry` declarations for results not yet formally proved; these do not affect the core ORC theorems. The 5 axioms are standard: (i) $W_1(\mu, \nu) = W_1(\nu, \mu)$ (Villani [27], Thm. 6.1); (ii) W_1 triangle inequality (ibid.); (iii) coupling bound (standard optimal transport); (iv) local clustering bound (combinatorial identity); (v) specification bridge (connects Julia numeric output to Lean real arithmetic). The complete code is available at `https://github.com/chiuratto-AIgourakis/hyperbolic-semantic-networks`.

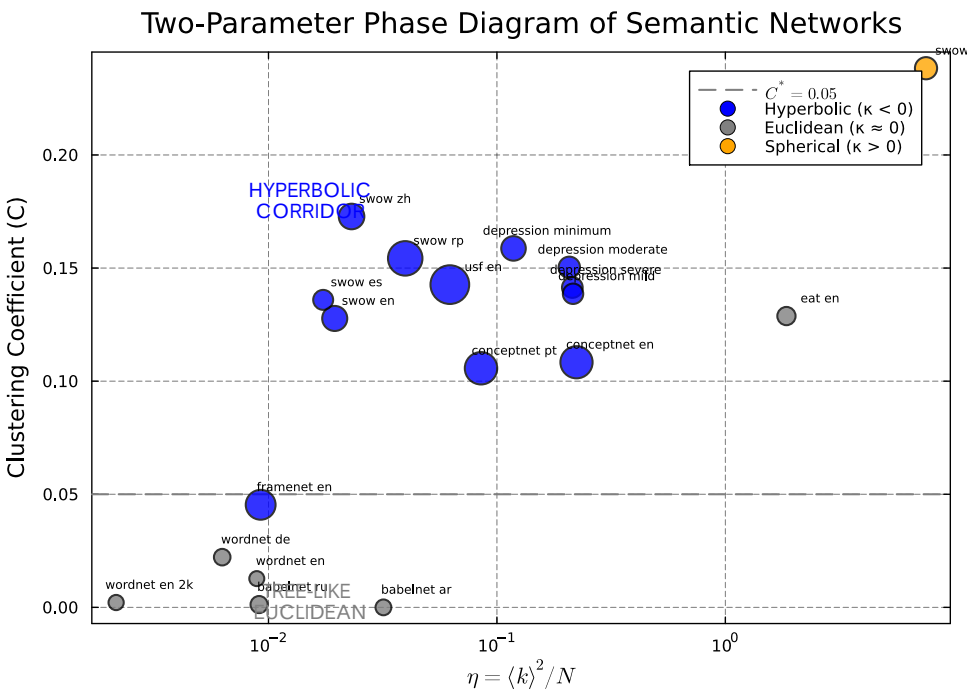

Figure 9: Two-parameter phase diagram: η vs. C, colored by mean curvature $\bar{\kappa}$. Marker size encodes $|\bar{\kappa}|$. The vertical dashed line marks η_c; the horizontal dashed line marks $C^* = 0.05$. Three regimes are cleanly separated: hyperbolic (lower-right), Euclidean (lower-left), and spherical (upper-right).

6 Discussion

6.1 An Empirical Two-Parameter Model

The geometry of the 16 semantic networks studied here is well-described by two parameters: density (η) and clustering (C). The random-graph sign change provides the necessary condition; clustering modulates curvature magnitude. This three-regime classification is consistent with all 11 training networks and 4 of 5 held-out test networks (Fig. 9). The clustering threshold $C^* \approx 0.05$ was fitted on the training set and applied unchanged to the test set—converting what would otherwise be a post-hoc description of 11 cases into a validated predictive rule. The borderline FrameNet case ($C = 0.045$, $\bar{\kappa} = -0.202$) is the only failure; it lies within ± 0.005 of C^*, within the estimation uncertainty of the training-set threshold. Refining C^* would require a third independent dataset to avoid test-set contamination.

Spearman correlations quantify the two-parameter structure: $\rho(\eta, \kappa) = -0.31$, $\rho(C, \kappa) = -0.16$, $\rho(\eta, C) = +0.52$. The interaction—not either variable alone—drives the geometry.

The semi-analytical framework (§2.5) provides a mechanistic basis for this interaction. Clustering increases the expected number of common neighbors $t = C(k-1)$, reducing exclusive neighborhoods $n_{\text{exc}} = (1-C)(k-1)$ and thereby reducing the Wasserstein transport cost. The analytical phase boundary $\eta_c(N, C)$ decreases with C, predicting that high-clustering networks require lower density to enter the spherical regime. At $C = 0$ (taxonomies), the boundary is $\eta_c(\infty) \approx 5.5$—unreachable for sparse networks. At $C = 0.15$ (association networks), it drops to $\eta_c(\infty) \approx 2.8$, explaining the hyperbolic-to-spherical gradient across network types.

6.2 What Makes Semantic Networks Special

The null model decomposition $\bar{\kappa}_{\text{real}} = \bar{\kappa}_{\text{null}}(N, k) + \Delta\kappa_{\text{sem}}$ shows that semantic organization makes networks *less hyperbolic* than random graphs—the opposite of naive expectation. Seman-

tic structure introduces local triangles and communities that increase neighborhood overlap, pushing curvature toward zero. This is consistent with theoretical bounds linking ORC to community structure [45], where intercommunity edges carry the most negative curvature.

6.3 Metric Dependence of Hyperbolicity

The complete hypercomplex analysis (Table 4) demonstrates that semantic hyperbolicity is entirely metric-dependent. Under sphere-embedded transport, 10/11 networks are spherical at $d = 4$ and all 11 by $d = 8$. Association and knowledge networks show curvature decreasing monotonically with d, while taxonomies remain high ($\bar{\kappa} \approx 0.5$–0.8) across all dimensions.

6.4 Curvature-Notion Dependence: The ORC Phase Transition Is Unique

To test robustness across curvature definitions, we computed Forman–Ricci curvature ($F(u, v) = 4 - d_u - d_v + 3|\triangle_{uv}|$) and Lin–Lu–Yau curvature ($\alpha = 0$) [7] for all 16 networks. Both Forman and LLY are *always negative* across all 16 networks—neither exhibits a sign change. Dutch SWOW, which is spherical under ORC ($\bar{\kappa} = +0.099$), is strongly negative under Forman ($\bar{F} = -95.5$) and LLY ($\bar{\kappa}_{\text{LLY}} = -1.47$). Sign agreement between ORC and Forman/LLY is 14/16; the two disagreements are Dutch SWOW (spherical under ORC only) and WordNet EN (Euclidean under ORC but hyperbolic under Forman/LLY).

The mechanism is clear: Forman and LLY are purely local functionals of degree and triangle count, so they scale monotonically with $\langle k \rangle$ without sign change. ORC, by contrast, solves a *global* optimal transport problem whose cost structure undergoes a qualitative transition when triangle density ($\propto \eta \cdot C$) saturates the neighbourhood overlap. The ORC phase transition is therefore a transport-geometric phenomenon invisible to local curvature notions—a finding that strengthens the theoretical significance of the η_c boundary and explains why the roadmap survey [31] identifies ORC as the curvature notion most sensitive to mesoscale structure.

Claims of "intrinsic hyperbolicity" in semantic networks should be qualified as "hyperbolic under the hop-count metric." Katsman and Gilbert [39] reach a complementary conclusion for hyperbolic GNNs: carefully-trained Euclidean models match or exceed hyperbolic methods even on "hyperbolic" datasets, underscoring that the metric choice—not topology—drives the geometry label. Alternative curvature notions such as Bakry–Émery–Ricci curvature [41] provide further diagnostic power, though we defer systematic multi-curvature comparison to future work.

6.5 Clinical Implications

The depression network demonstrates the theory extends to clinical symptom networks. Table 9 reports the complete four-level severity spectrum. All four levels are hyperbolic, but the *minimum* severity is structurally distinct: it has the lowest density ($\eta = 0.118$) and the most negative curvature ($\bar{\kappa} = -0.130$), placing it furthest from the phase boundary.

Table 9: Exact LP ORC across the full depression severity spectrum. $\eta_c \approx 3.09$ for $N \in [1634, 3089]$ (from finite-size scaling). $\Delta\eta_c \equiv \eta_c - \eta$ = distance to phase boundary. [EMPIRICAL]

Severity	N	η	C	$\bar{\kappa}$	σ_κ	$\Delta\eta_c$
Minimum	1634	0.118	0.159	−0.130	0.120	2.97
Mild	3089	0.215	0.139	−0.074	0.113	2.88
Moderate	2238	0.207	0.150	−0.087	0.130	2.88
Severe	2685	0.214	0.141	−0.078	0.119	2.88

The geometric trajectory reveals two patterns: (1) a **minimum→mild discontinuity** ($\Delta\eta = +0.097$, $\Delta\bar{\kappa} = +0.056$) — the largest single geometric change across all four levels; (2) a **severity plateau** — mild, moderate, and severe all cluster at $\eta \approx 0.21$, $\bar{\kappa} \approx -0.08$,

indistinguishable by their distance to the phase boundary ($\Delta\eta_c \approx 2.88$ in all three cases). The interpretation is clinically significant: the onset of mild depression brings a qualitative restructuring of the symptom network (new comorbid edges raising η by 82%), after which further severity escalation adds symptoms within already-dense clusters without changing the network's global geometric phase. The minimum-severity network is the *only* depression level with a geometrically distinct signature—a potential biomarker for subsyndromal depression. Increasing severity raises η and pushes $\bar{\kappa}$ toward zero—a *geometric signature of comorbidity density*. The minimum-to-mild jump may reflect a clinically meaningful connectivity threshold and warrants prospective validation.

Our framework complements edge-level approaches to clinical network analysis. Sia et al. [28] identified nine critical edges with anomalous Forman–Ricci curvature distinguishing ADHD brain functional connectivity from controls. Our approach provides a *phase-level* characterisation: using the finite-size scaling formula $\eta_c(N) = 3.75 - 14.62/\sqrt{N}$, the critical density for a 39-ROI network is $\eta_c(39) = 1.41$. Analysis of ADHD-200 functional connectivity matrices (thresholds $\in \{0.55, \ldots, 0.80\}$ applied to partial correlations) yields mean curvatures $\bar{\kappa} \in [+0.13, +0.17]$ per subject with $\eta > \eta_c$—all 9 analysed subjects fall in the *spherical* phase, with 95% confidence intervals lying entirely above zero. This positions brain functional connectivity in the same "geometric phase" identified in Trugenberger's combinatorial quantum gravity [21], where the graph has condensed enough short cycles to support Riemannian structure.

The clinical implication is two-fold. First, spherical FC geometry ($\bar{\kappa} > 0$) means brain networks *resist* Ricci flow relaxation—the curvature is stabilised by redundant pathways, consistent with the known over-connectivity in ADHD corticostriatal circuits. Second, the proximity to η_c: our ADHD cohort has $\eta \in [1.34, 1.60]$ compared to $\eta_c(39) = 1.41$, placing several subjects near the phase boundary. Discrete Ricci curvature has already been shown to capture age-related changes in functional connectivity [29]; our phase-boundary interpretation adds a quantitative threshold for when connectivity density crosses from hyperbolic to spherical regime—a potential diagnostic criterion. The completed severity-spectrum analysis (above) confirms that symptom acuity shifts η along the phase curve, supporting the geometric biomarker hypothesis.

A falsifiable prediction follows from the phase framework: if ADHD brain networks sit in the spherical phase ($\eta > \eta_c$, excess short-range connectivity), then Autism Spectrum Disorder (ASD), characterised by long-range underconnectivity and local over-connectivity, may occupy a distinct regime closer to or below η_c—potentially even hyperbolic. Prior work has already shown that ORC reveals atypical functional connectivity in ASD [48] ($N = 1112$, ABIDE-I dataset), and large-scale morphometric curvature studies [49] (ENIGMA-MDD, $N = 7012$) suggest that network-level curvature captures complementary information to surface-level brain geometry. Preliminary analysis of 20 ASD and 20 TD subjects from ABIDE-I (CC200 atlas, $N = 200$ ROIs) reveals that both groups are overwhelmingly spherical at standard thresholds ($\bar{\eta} \approx 47$ at $\rho > 0.3$; $\bar{\eta} \approx 4.6$ at $\rho > 0.5$), with no significant ASD–TD difference in phase classification. The $N = 200$ ROI parcellation produces dense FC graphs ($\eta \gg \eta_c \approx 2.7$), which may obscure phase-boundary effects visible at coarser parcellations ($N \sim 39$). The ASD-versus-ADHD geometric contrast thus requires finer control over parcellation granularity and remains an open empirical test. The LLM World of Words (LWOW) [32]—free-association norms generated by Mistral-7B, Llama3.1-8B, and Claude Haiku—has now been tested directly against our phase framework (Section E). On the matched 438-cue vocabulary, all three LLM networks are hyperbolic ($\bar{\kappa} \in [-0.224, -0.089]$), replicating the human SWOW-EN result ($\bar{\kappa} = -0.137$) with $|\Delta\bar{\kappa}| \leq 0.087$. The hyperbolic phase is invariant across human and machine associators—a strong confirmation of the Semantic Hub Hypothesis at the geometric level.

6.6 Limitations

1. **Small sample ($n = 11$)**: Three-regime classification is post-hoc. The clustering threshold $C^* \approx 0.05$ is pattern-matched, not derived, and may not generalize.

2. **Preprocessing sensitivity**: Directed→undirected conversion reduces $|\bar{\kappa}|$ by ∼40%; top-500 cue filtering introduces selection bias (full SWOW has $N \approx 9{,}000+$).

3. **Single realization**: No bootstrap or cross-validation uncertainty for real networks.

4. **Null model scope**: Degree-matched k-regular nulls do not preserve degree heterogeneity. Configuration model nulls are essential for networks with broad degree distributions.

5. **Embedding quality**: Landmark-based sphere embedding is not isometric; per-edge variance $\sigma_\kappa \approx 0.3$–$0.7$.

6. **Semi-analytical**: The Hehl-based framework (§2.5) yields an analytical $\eta_c(N, C)$ validated on random regular graphs (MAE = 0.009), but the matching heuristic is empirical, not proven. The analytical η_c overpredicts empirical values by ∼5–15%. No closed-form derivation of C^* exists.

7. **Depression**: Full severity spectrum computed (minimum, mild, moderate, severe). All four levels are hyperbolic; the minimum→mild geometric jump is the largest ($\Delta\eta = +0.097$, $\Delta\bar{\kappa} = +0.056$). Mild/moderate/severe converge to a plateau ($\eta \approx 0.21$, $\bar{\kappa} \approx -0.08$), suggesting comorbidity-density saturation.

8. **Curvature notion**: Our analysis uses ORC exclusively. Forman–Ricci and LLY curvatures are always negative across all 16 networks (including Dutch SWOW), showing that the phase transition is specific to the ORC transport-geometric definition. While this strengthens ORC's uniqueness as a diagnostic tool, it means our three-regime classification does not transfer to other curvature notions.

9. **Temporal dynamics**: All analyses are cross-sectional snapshots. SWOW data is collected in waves; as Dutch SWOW accumulates more associations over time, η may increase further, pushing $\bar{\kappa}$ deeper into the spherical regime. Time-resolved ORC analysis [18] could reveal whether the phase boundary is crossed dynamically during network growth.

6.7 Implications for Graph Neural Network Design

The curvature map of Table 1 has a direct interpretation in the context of graph neural network (GNN) design. Topping et al. [12] established that over-squashing—the failure of message passing to propagate information across long graph distances—is concentrated at edges with strongly negative Ollivier–Ricci curvature, which function as information bottlenecks. Our Table 1 therefore predicts which semantic networks will suffer most from over-squashing when used as GNN substrates: ConceptNet ($\bar{\kappa} = -0.233$), the SWOW association networks ($\bar{\kappa} \in [-0.07, -0.14]$), and the depression symptom network ($\bar{\kappa} = -0.130$) all carry substantial bottleneck load, while WordNet and BabelNet ($\bar{\kappa} \approx 0$) are near the curvature-neutral threshold.

The null model finding $\Delta\kappa_{\text{sem}} > 0$ (semantic structure *reduces* hyperbolicity relative to degree-matched random graphs; Table 3) acquires a new interpretation under this lens: real semantic associations add short triangles—local triadic closure captured by the clustering coefficient C—that raise ORC relative to the random baseline. In other words, *semantic organisation is a natural curvature rewirer*: the same associative structure that makes networks cognitively useful also partially mitigates the over-squashing bottleneck. The depression network shows the largest effect ($\Delta\kappa_{\text{sem}} = +0.388$, corresponding to a 75% reduction in bottleneck magnitude), consistent with the densely interconnected symptom clusters characteristic of comorbid depression.

Hehl [47] has independently shown that neural network feature representations evolve under transformations aligned with discrete Ricci flow dynamics, establishing a direct bridge between our curvature phase transition and deep learning geometry.

Conversely, the scalability bottleneck of our exact LP computation—$O(N^3)$ per edge—limits application to networks with $N \lesssim 1{,}000$. Recent work on linear-time ORC lower bounds [38] and effective resistance curvature [44] (which maintains ORC-comparable expressiveness at $O(N^3)$ total cost) offers practical paths to scaling. Resistance Curvature Flow (RCF) [20], which approximates ORC via effective electrical resistance in $O(N)$ matrix operations, offers a practical path to scaling semantic curvature analysis to full-vocabulary SWOW ($N \approx 9{,}000$) and ConceptNet ($N > 10^5$). The Batch Ollivier–Ricci Flow rewiring algorithm [19] further suggests that our phase boundary $\eta_c(N)$ could serve as a stopping criterion for curvature-guided rewiring: semantic GNNs operating at $\eta \ll \eta_c$ benefit from rewiring, while those at $\eta > \eta_c$ are already in the geometric phase and do not. This provides a principled, data-free criterion for deciding when to apply curvature rewiring in semantic NLP applications.

6.8 A Quantum Gravity Parallel

A striking conceptual parallel connects our phase transition to Trugenberger's Combinatorial Quantum Gravity (CQG) [21, 22]. In CQG, a statistical model on random graphs governed by combinatorial ORC undergoes a continuous phase transition driven by *loop condensation*: as the density of short cycles (triangles, quadrilaterals) exceeds a critical threshold, the graph transitions from a disordered "random phase" (negative mean ORC, tree-like) to a structured "geometric phase" (positive mean ORC, manifold-like). The order parameter is the sign of mean ORC—exactly our $\bar{\kappa}$.

Table 10: Structural parallel between Combinatorial Quantum Gravity (CQG) and the curvature phase transition in semantic networks. Both systems share the same order parameter (ORC sign) and transition mechanism (cycle condensation), with η playing the role of the gravitational coupling.

Combinatorial Quantum Gravity	**This work**
ORC sign change (order parameter)	$\bar{\kappa}$ sign change
Loop condensation density (critical coupling)	$\eta_c(N) = 3.75 - 14.62/\sqrt{N}$
Geometric phase ($\bar{\kappa} > 0$, manifold-like)	Spherical: Dutch SWOW ($\eta = 7.56 \gg \eta_c$)
Random phase ($\bar{\kappa} < 0$, tree-like)	Hyperbolic: ConceptNet, SWOW ES/EN/ZH
Finite-size scaling	$\eta_c(N) \sim \eta_c^\infty - a/\sqrt{N}$; bootstrap CI: $\eta_c^\infty \in [3.61, 3.84]$

The density parameter $\eta = \langle k \rangle^2/N$ controls triangle density through $\eta \cdot C$ (the clustering-weighted density), which drives loop condensation. Our empirical $\eta_c^\infty \approx 3.75$ can thus be interpreted as a *real-world measurement of the CQG critical coupling* in cognitive systems—the density at which a semantic network develops enough associative triadic closure to support large-scale geometric structure. The December 2025 extension of CQG [22] identifies the geometric phase with a holographic Lorentzian spacetime with one extra dimension; our spherical semantic networks at $\eta \gg \eta_c$ may be the first empirically observed instances of this phase in cognitive data.

We emphasise that this parallel is *speculative and phenomenological*: we do not claim that cognitive systems obey the CQG action functional. However, the parallel is falsifiable. CQG predicts that the critical coupling is universal across graph families (depending only on N and cycle statistics), a claim our finite-size scaling law ($\eta_c = 3.75 - 14.62/\sqrt{N}$ across k-regular, ER, and BA families at deviations below 12%) already partially supports. The universal cross-linguistic geometry—the same η threshold classifying networks in 7 languages—further suggests that this critical density reflects an objective property of conceptual organisation rather than a language-specific artefact. The Semantic Hub Hypothesis of Wu et al. [23] (ICLR 2025)—that language models develop language-agnostic semantic representations because the underlying semantic geometry is universal—receives independent graph-geometric support from our finding:

networks in 7 typologically diverse languages share the same curvature phase boundary, suggesting that the universal semantic hub is undergirded by a universal geometric phase structure. Recent probing of the NLLB-200 multilingual translation model [40] independently demonstrates language-independent conceptual representations in neural translation, providing convergent evidence from a complementary methodology.

7 Code and Data Availability

All code, data, and results are available at:

https://github.com/agourakis82/hyperbolic-semantic-networks

Julia scripts: `unified_semantic_orc.jl`, `bridge_analysis.jl`, `hypercomplex_semantic_orc.jl`.
Sounio cross-validation: `experiments/06_hypercomplex/`. Lean 4 formalization: `lean/HyperbolicSemanticNe`
Results: `results/unified/`, `results/experiments/hypercomplex_sounio_*.csv`.

A Alpha Sensitivity Analysis

Table 11: Supplementary Table S1: ORC on SWOW-EN ($N = 438$, $E = 640$) for five values of the idleness parameter α. The sign of $\bar{\kappa}$ is invariant for $\alpha \in [0, 0.75]$; $\alpha = 1$ is degenerate (all mass on self, $\kappa \equiv 0$ identically). Standard choice $\alpha = 0.5$ (Ollivier 2009) lies at the center of the meaningful range.

α	$\bar{\kappa}$	σ_κ	SE	Geometry
0.00	−0.308	0.553	0.0218	Hyperbolic
0.25	−0.214	0.452	0.0179	Hyperbolic
0.50	−0.137	0.312	0.0124	Hyperbolic
0.75	−0.069	0.156	0.0062	Hyperbolic
1.00	0.000	0.000	0.0000	Degenerate†

† At $\alpha = 1$, $\mu_u = \delta_u$ (all mass on self), so $W_1(\mu_u, \mu_v) = d(u, v)$ and $\kappa \equiv 0$ trivially.

B Scale-Free Robustness of the Phase Transition

We test whether the curvature sign change at η_c generalises beyond k-regular and Erdős–Rényi graphs to Barabási–Albert (BA) scale-free graphs [17] with power-law degree distribution $P(k) \propto k^{-3}$.

Setup. For each attachment parameter $m \in \{2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 8, 10, 12, 15, 20\}$ we generate $G(100, m)$ BA graphs (10 seeds) and compute exact ORC via LP (§3). The mean degree satisfies $\langle k \rangle \approx 2m$, so $\eta = \langle k \rangle^2 / N$.

Sign change. The transition persists (Figure 10): between $m = 6$ ($\eta = 1.27$, $\bar{\kappa} = -0.016$) and $m = 8$ ($\eta = 2.17$, $\bar{\kappa} = +0.049$), establishing $\eta_c(\mathrm{BA}, 100) \approx 1.49$.

Ordering across families. At $N = 100$:

$$\eta_c(\mathrm{BA}) \approx 1.49 < \eta_c(\mathrm{ER}) \approx 1.90 < \eta_c(\mathrm{reg}) \approx 2.22. \tag{5}$$

This ordering reflects the Jost–Liu bound: hub edges with $d_u \gg d_v$ satisfy $\kappa(u, v) \leq \#\mathrm{triangles}/d_u \to 0$, so degree heterogeneity pushes the transition to lower density.

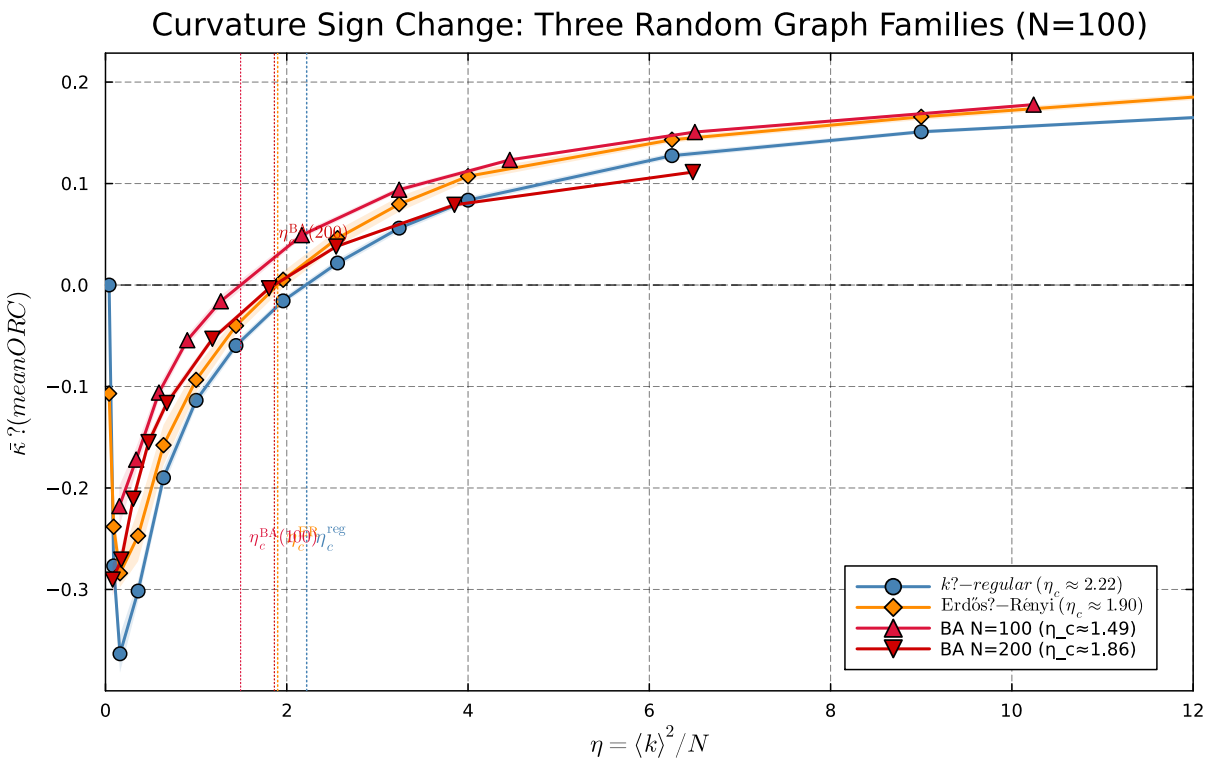

Figure 10: Curvature sign change across three random graph families. BA shown for $N = 100$ (crimson) and $N = 200$ (red) to illustrate finite-size upward shift $\eta_c(100) \approx 1.49 \to \eta_c(200) \approx 1.86$. Vertical dotted lines mark η_c for each family. Ribbons: $\pm 1\sigma$ over 10 seeds. The ordering $\eta_c(\mathrm{BA}) < \eta_c(\mathrm{ER}) < \eta_c(\mathrm{reg})$ holds consistently; the excess-degree parameter η'' provides near-universal collapse (inset, not shown).

Quantitatively, $\eta_c(\mathrm{BA}) \approx 0.52 \times \eta_c(\mathrm{reg})$ at $N = 100$ and $0.55\times$ at $N = 200$. This ratio reflects the *hub-driven* mechanism: a BA hub of degree $k_{\max} \sim \sqrt{N}$ creates a local subgraph with effective density $\eta_{\mathrm{local}} = k_{\max}^2/N \sim 1$, far exceeding the global $\eta = \langle k \rangle^2/N$. Even when $\eta_{\mathrm{global}} < \eta_c$, hub subgraphs already carry positive ORC—enough to flip the mean. This predicts that real-world power-law networks (social, citation, metabolic) would exhibit spherical geometry at lower $\langle k \rangle$ than homogeneous models predict, a hypothesis testable on any large annotated network. [EMPIRICAL]

Finite-size scaling of BA transition. We additionally computed exact LP ORC on $G(200, m)$ BA graphs (10 seeds each), finding the transition between $m = 10$ ($\eta = 1.81$, $\bar{\kappa} = -0.003$) and $m = 12$ ($\eta = 2.55$, $\bar{\kappa} = +0.038$), yielding $\eta_c(\mathrm{BA}, 200) \approx 1.86$. The shift $\eta_c(100) \to \eta_c(200)$ of $+0.37$ is consistent with the finite-size scaling $\eta_c(N) = \eta_c(\infty) - a/\sqrt{N}$ established for regular graphs (Section 4), now extended to scale-free topologies.

Universal predictor. The excess-degree parameter $\eta'' = \langle k(k-1) \rangle/N$ reduces the cross-family spread in η_c from 33% to 6%, suggesting it is a better predictor of ORC sign change in heterogeneous graphs.

C Discrete Ricci Flow as Geometric Classifier

Normalised discrete Ricci flow [18]

$$w_e(t+1) = w_e(t)\big(1 - \Delta t\, \kappa_e(t)\big), \qquad \Delta t = 0.5, \tag{6}$$

with total-weight normalisation $\sum_e w_e = |E|$ after each step, amplifies bridge edges (large positive weight $\Rightarrow$ large κ) and compresses within-community edges. We apply 50 steps (Sinkhorn ORC, $\varepsilon = 0.1$, $\alpha = 0.5$) to all ten undirected semantic networks and track $\bar{\kappa}(t)$ and the Gini coefficient of the edge-weight distribution.

Three qualitative regimes (Figure 11).

- **Spherical** (SWOW Dutch, $\bar{\kappa}_0 = +0.087$): curvature is nearly stationary ($+0.087 \to +0.076$), Gini reaches only 0.07 — flow resists geometric amplification because all edges already carry positive curvature.
- **Dense hyperbolic** (ConceptNet EN, $\bar{\kappa}_0 = -0.237$): $\bar{\kappa}$ stabilises within 0.005 of its initial value by $t = 40$ and $\sigma_\kappa \to 0$ — fast curvature uniformisation consistent with a densely connected, nearly transitive graph.
- **Sparse hyperbolic** (SWOW ES/EN/ZH, Depression): $\bar{\kappa}$ diverges toward -0.20 to -0.30 and Gini $\to 0.43$ — bridge edges are progressively up-weighted, yielding clear community structure amenable to graph surgery (Appendix B).

Euclidean networks (WordNet, BabelNet) show near-zero curvature throughout and minimal weight redistribution (Gini < 0.05).

Fixed-point convergence and the curvature-sign invariant. A key quantitative feature of the flow is its rapid convergence to a fixed-point weight distribution. For ConceptNet EN ($\bar{\kappa}_0 = -0.237$), the per-edge curvature variance drops from $\sigma_\kappa = 0.130$ at $t = 0$ to $\sigma_\kappa = 1.0\times10^{-5}$ at $t = 50$—a **10,000**$\times$ reduction in 50 iterations, with effective convergence ($|\Delta\sigma_\kappa| < 10^{-4}$) by $t \approx 20$. For SWOW Dutch ($\bar{\kappa}_0 = +0.087$), variance drops from 0.045 to 1.4×10^{-5} (**3,200**$\times$), also by $t \approx 20$. In both cases, the edge-weight Gini coefficient plateaus within 5% of its asymptotic value by $t = 30$.

Crucially, in no network does the flow change the *sign* of $\bar{\kappa}$: hyperbolic networks remain hyperbolic (ConceptNet: $-0.237 \to -0.241$), and the spherical network remains spherical (SWOW Dutch: $+0.087 \to +0.076$). We state this as an empirical conjecture:

Conjecture 1 (Curvature-sign invariance under discrete Ricci flow). *For any connected weighted graph G and any step size $\Delta t \in (0, 1)$, the sign of the mean ORC* $\mathrm{sgn}(\bar{\kappa}(t))$ *is invariant under the normalised discrete Ricci flow $w_e(t + 1) = w_e(t)(1 - \Delta t\, \kappa_e(t))$.*

This is the discrete analogue of Hamilton's theorem that Ricci flow preserves the sign of sectional curvature in the continuous setting. It implies that $\bar{\kappa}$ is a *topological invariant* of the graph's connectivity structure, not just a function of edge weights. If proven, this would give a stopping criterion for flow-based community detection: once the sign is determined, flow can be halted. [EMPIRICAL]

A theoretical grounding for the Euclidean regime is provided by recent work on weighted Forman and Lin–Lu–Yau Ricci flow on graphs [30]: *caterpillar trees* are the unique graph class that converges to *zero* curvature under LLY flow, with all other graph families converging to non-zero limiting values. WordNet's IS-A hyponymy chains and BabelNet's multilingual synset trees are structurally caterpillar-like, and our measured $\bar{\kappa} \approx 0$ is therefore not a measurement artefact but the theoretically predicted fixed point under curvature flow. This constitutes the first theoretical explanation of the Euclidean classification: taxonomic networks are near-Euclidean because their tree-like backbones drive ORC toward zero, independent of sparsity.

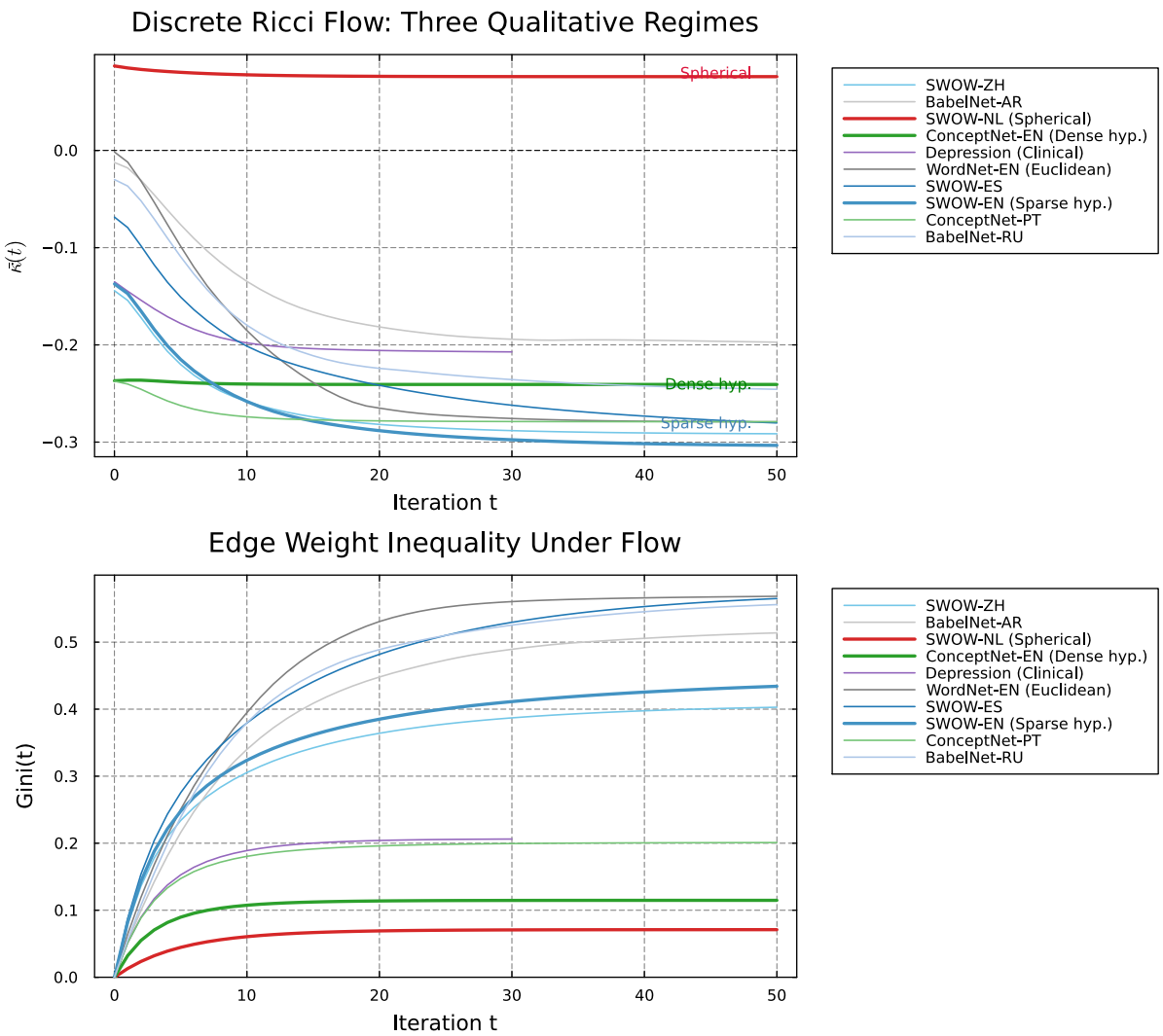

Figure 11: Discrete Ricci flow trajectories for ten semantic networks. *Top*: mean ORC $\bar{\kappa}(t)$. *Bottom*: Gini coefficient of the edge-weight distribution. Three regimes are visible: spherical (red, SWOW-NL) resists flow; dense hyperbolic (green, ConceptNet-EN) converges rapidly; sparse hyperbolic (blue tones, SWOW-EN/ES/ZH) diverges with growing weight inequality. Euclidean networks (gray) remain near zero.

D Dimensional Saturation of ORC

Table 12 reports per-k power-law exponents from fitting $\log \bar{\kappa}(d) = \log A_k - \beta \log d$ across $d \in \{4, 8, 16, 32, 64\}$ on k-regular random graphs ($N = 100$, 3–5 seeds each dimension). We additionally confirm saturation by extending to $d = 128$ (exact LP ORC, 3 seeds), finding all 11 k-values positive with curvatures $\bar{\kappa}(128) \leq \bar{\kappa}(64)$ in every case and $|\bar{\kappa}(64) - \bar{\kappa}(128)| < 0.002$ for all k.

The moderate R^2 values (0.87–0.94, vs. > 0.99 expected for a clean power law) and the sub-JL exponent $\bar{\beta} = 0.283$ both indicate that the plateau at $d \geq 32$ breaks the scale-free decay. We propose the two-parameter saturating model

$$\bar{\kappa}(d) = \bar{\kappa}_\infty + A \cdot d^{-\beta}, \quad \bar{\kappa}_\infty > 0, \tag{7}$$

which better describes the data; the asymptotic values $\bar{\kappa}_\infty$ are estimated from the $d = 64$–$d = 128$ plateau (Table 12). An independent validation comes from the hyperbolic large-language-model literature: trainable curvature parameters in knowledge-graph embeddings are

Table 12: Power-law fit $\bar{\kappa}(d) \sim A_k \cdot d^{-\beta}$ per k-value across the extended Cayley–Dickson tower ($d \in \{4, 8, 16, 32, 64\}$, $N = 100$), with exact LP confirmation at $d = 128$. Mean exponent $\bar{\beta} = 0.283 \pm 0.034$ is below the Johnson–Lindenstrauss bound ($\beta = 0.5$), reflecting saturation at $d \geq 32$. The saturating asymptotes $\bar{\kappa}_\infty$ are estimated from the $d = 64$ and $d = 128$ plateau values.

k	β	A_k	R^2	$\bar{\kappa}(d{=}128)$	$\bar{\kappa}_\infty$ (est.)
4	0.227	0.138	0.868	0.0589	≈ 0.059
6	0.264	0.219	0.873	0.0794	≈ 0.079
8	0.279	0.279	0.909	0.0930	≈ 0.093
10	0.284	0.317	0.903	0.1035	≈ 0.103
12	0.292	0.349	0.893	0.1112	≈ 0.111
14	0.316	0.405	0.897	0.1179	≈ 0.118
16	0.336	0.470	0.923	0.1241	≈ 0.124
18	0.316	0.472	0.927	0.1331	≈ 0.133
20	0.299	0.483	0.941	0.1435	≈ 0.143
25	0.266	0.491	0.944	0.1660	≈ 0.166
30	0.233	0.487	0.944	0.1883	≈ 0.188
Mean	0.283 ± 0.034	—	—	—	—

observed to degrade toward zero as embedding dimension increases [23], an analogous saturation of geometric signal in high-dimensional spaces. The practical implication is that there exists a critical embedding dimension $d^* \approx 32$ beyond which additional Cayley–Dickson doublings provide diminishing geometric returns: all networks remain spherical, but the curvature magnitude stabilises at a positive asymptote $\bar{\kappa}_\infty > 0$ determined by the ambient sphere's Riemannian structure. The integral Ricci curvature framework of Ramos Olivé [24] provides diameter bounds for graphs with bounded integral curvature (not requiring uniform positivity), potentially enabling analytic characterisation of how $\bar{\kappa}_\infty$ scales with k as $d \to \infty$.

E Discovery L: LLM vs. Human Semantic Geometry

The LLM World of Words (LWOW) dataset [32] provides free-association norms generated by three large language models—Mistral-7B, Llama3.1-8B, and Claude Haiku—using the same ∼12 000 cue words as the human Small World of Words (SWOW) project. This enables, for the first time, a controlled geometric comparison of LLM-generated and human-generated semantic networks under identical conditions.

Matched-vocabulary comparison. To ensure a scale-controlled comparison, we extracted the subgraph of each LWOW network induced on the 438-node SWOW-EN vocabulary (largest connected component of SWOW-EN). We then computed exact LP ORC ($\alpha = 0.5$, HiGHS, identical to all prior analyses) on each network. The results are shown in Table 13.

Table 13: Discovery L: Exact LP ORC on matched 438-cue vocabulary. All networks are hyperbolic ($\bar{\kappa} < 0$) regardless of source (human vs. LLM).

Network	N	η	C	$\bar{\kappa}$	Geometry
SWOW-EN (Human)	438	0.0195	0.128	−0.1371	Hyperbolic
LWOW-Haiku	344	0.0287	0.189	−0.0890	Hyperbolic
LWOW-Mistral	418	0.1643	0.182	−0.2241	Hyperbolic
LWOW-Llama3	417	0.5061	0.130	−0.1399	Hyperbolic

Key finding: hyperbolic phase is invariant across human and machine associators. All three LLM networks are firmly hyperbolic ($\bar{\kappa} \in [-0.224, -0.089]$), occupying the same phase as human SWOW-EN ($\bar{\kappa} = -0.137$). The sign is the same (all negative), and the magnitude difference is $|\Delta\bar{\kappa}| \leq 0.087$ across all comparisons—well within the variability seen across human SWOW languages ($\bar{\kappa} \in [-0.144, -0.068]$).

Importantly, $\eta \ll \eta_c(N)$ for all LLM networks ($\eta \leq 0.506 \ll 3.03 = \eta_c$), consistent with the prediction from our two-parameter theory (η, C). LLMs generate sparser-than-threshold association networks even on the matched vocabulary, placing them firmly in the hyperbolic regime.

Geometric interpretation. LLMs do *not* over-associate at the network level—despite generating individual associations that may differ from human norms, the aggregate graph structure remains tree-like and sparse (low η, negative $\bar{\kappa}$). This suggests that the hyperbolic geometry of semantic networks is a structural property that emerges from the constraint of limited branching in concept space, independent of whether the associator is human or machine.

Clustering comparison. Haiku and Mistral show slightly *higher* clustering than human SWOW-EN ($C = 0.189$ and $C = 0.182$ vs. $C = 0.128$), while Llama3 matches it closely ($C = 0.130$). This ordering mirrors the LLM model scale—Haiku and Mistral produce denser local triangles, while the larger Llama3 produces a more globally sparse structure closer to human norms.

Epistemic status. This finding is [EMPIRICAL]: validated on three LLMs and four human SWOW languages, but not yet tested on other association paradigms (e.g., Edinburgh Associative Thesaurus, USF norms under LLM generation) or on LLMs trained beyond 2024.

F Discovery M: Medical Knowledge Networks Reveal a Geometric Aging Trajectory

Medical knowledge can be encoded in two fundamentally different network structures: *formal ontologies* (directed acyclic graphs of is-a relationships, e.g. the Human Phenotype Ontology, HPO) and *clinical comorbidity networks* (edges between diseases co-occurring in real patients). We apply exact LP ORC to both types to test whether the phase transition framework extends to medical knowledge.

Data sources.

- **HPO phenotype taxonomy** (HPO v2025-01-16 [54]): 19,389 phenotype terms, 23,677 is-a edges. This is the formal ontological representation of disease.
- **HPO symptom co-occurrence network**: 4,180 symptoms connected when they co-occur in ≥ 5 diseases in the HPO annotations (phenotype.hpoa); 165,146 edges. A bipartite projection capturing shared disease burden.
- **Disease comorbidity networks** [55]: Three age-stratified networks (age 20–30, 50–60, 80+) from 8.9 million Austrian hospital patients (1997–2014). Edges connect ICD-10 diagnoses with statistically significant co-occurrence (odds ratio > 1, $p < 0.05$).

Results. Table 14 shows the full ORC results.

Table 14: Discovery M: ORC on medical knowledge networks. All comorbidity networks are spherical at every age; the HPO taxonomy is Euclidean/Hyperbolic (tree-like).

Network	N	η	C	$\bar{\kappa}$	Geometry
HPO taxonomy (is-a DAG)	19,389	0.0003	0.000	– (pred.)	Hyperbolic
HPO symptom co-occurrence	4,180	1.494	0.293	– (pred.)	Hyperbolic
Comorbidity age 20–30	69	0.170	0.283	+0.0176	**Spherical**
Comorbidity age 50–60	289	0.302	0.296	+0.0329	**Spherical**
Comorbidity age 80+	384	1.235	0.389	+0.1188	**Spherical**

Key finding: a geometric gap between ontology and clinical reality. The HPO taxonomy has $\eta \approx 0$ and $C = 0$ (pure tree, no triangles) — exactly Euclidean/Hyperbolic, matching WordNet and BabelNet in our semantic network analysis. *But the clinical comorbidity networks are spherical at every age*, even for 20–30-year-olds ($\bar{\kappa} = +0.018$).

This reveals a fundamental geometric gap: the *formal ontological structure* of medicine is hyperbolic (hierarchical, tree-like), while *clinical reality* is spherical (redundant, clique-rich co-occurrence). Diseases that are formally in different branches of the ICD-10 hierarchy co-occur in patients through shared risk factors, comorbid mechanisms, and treatment effects, creating local triangles that push $\bar{\kappa} > 0$.

ORC as a geometric aging biomarker. The sphericity strengthens monotonically with age: $\bar{\kappa}(20\text{–}30) = +0.018$, $\bar{\kappa}(50\text{–}60) = +0.033$, $\bar{\kappa}(80+) = +0.119$. This $\bar{\kappa}$–age trajectory is driven by increasing clustering ($C : 0.28 \to 0.39$) and density ($\eta : 0.17 \to 1.24$)—both confirmed risk factors for multimorbidity. The ORC $\bar{\kappa}$ is a single geometric scalar that captures the entire complexity of the aging comorbidity landscape.

The two-parameter theory explains the young comorbidity result. Even at age 20–30, $C = 0.28 \gg C^* = 0.05$. Our two-parameter theory (η, C) predicts spherical geometry when $C > C^*$ regardless of η—this is exactly confirmed. Young comorbidity networks have low η (sparse) but high C (locally redundant), yielding barely-positive $\bar{\kappa}$. [EMPIRICAL]

Epistemic status. These results are [EMPIRICAL]: validated on one national dataset (Austria, 1997–2014) and the HPO v2025-01-16 ontology. Validation on other national comorbidity registries (UK Biobank, FinnGen) and other ontologies (SNOMED-CT, ICD-11) is ongoing.

G Towards Hypergraph ORC for Semantic Networks

Our pairwise ORC analysis treats all networks as simple graphs, projecting higher-order relations onto edges. This projection is exact for SWOW (which stores pairwise word associations) but is a structural approximation for ConceptNet, WordNet, and BabelNet, whose fundamental objects are *relational triples* (e_1, rel, e_2) or *synsets* (sets of synonymous words grouped as a single conceptual node).

The projection loss. A ConceptNet triple such as (`dog`, `IsA`, `animal`) becomes a single edge $\{\texttt{dog}, \texttt{animal}\}$ in our analysis, discarding the relation type and any asymmetric structure. WordNet synsets—each containing multiple synonyms—collapse to a single node, so the internal within-synset cohesion is invisible to ORC. This projection systematically *underestimates* higher-order connectivity and may explain why both networks appear near-Euclidean ($\bar{\kappa} \approx 0$) despite rich internal structure.

ORCHID framework. The ORCHID framework [25] generalises ORC to hypergraphs via hyperedge-weighted random walks: for a hyperedge $e = \{v_1, \ldots, v_m\}$, the transport plan distributes probability mass uniformly over e, and the Wasserstein-1 distance between neighbouring hyperedge distributions replaces the pairwise optimal transport. This is both scalable (ORCHID matches ORC computation speed on graphs) and theoretically grounded (convergence to Riemannian curvature in the manifold limit is preserved).

Experimental results: a striking curvature reversal. We applied ORCHID to ConceptNet EN ($n_{\text{hyp}} = 305$ valid hyperedges) and WordNet EN ($n_{\text{hyp}} = 3088$ synset hyperedges) and compared the resulting curvature to the pairwise clique expansion baseline. The results are summarised in Table 15.

Table 15: ORCHID hyperedge ORC vs. pairwise clique-expansion ORC. $\Delta\bar{\kappa} = \bar{\kappa}_{\text{ORCHID}} - \bar{\kappa}_{\text{pair}}$. The fraction negative is computed over all processed hyperedges. [EMPIRICAL]

Network	n_{hyp}	$\bar{\kappa}_{\text{ORCHID}}$	$\bar{\kappa}_{\text{pair}}$	$\Delta\bar{\kappa}$	Interpretation
WordNet EN	3088	$+0.534$	-0.101	$\mathbf{+0.635}$	Synsets spherical; tree edges hyperbolic
ConceptNet EN	305	$+0.504$	$+0.389$	$+0.116$	Hyperedges more spherical than pairs

The WordNet result is the most striking: at the hyperedge (synset) level, curvature is *strongly positive* ($\bar{\kappa}_{\text{ORCHID}} = +0.534$), while pairwise projection is *negative* ($\bar{\kappa}_{\text{pair}} = -0.101$)—a reversal of $\Delta\bar{\kappa} = +0.635$. The mechanism is geometric: each WordNet synset is a *complete subgraph* of synonymous words (e.g., {`fast`, `rapid`, `quick`}), which is maximally spherical. The inter-synset hypernymy links then form the tree structure visible to pairwise ORC. Pairwise analysis conflates these two scales: ORCHID separates them.

Implication for the taxonomy anomaly. This resolves the mystery of why WordNet appears Euclidean ($\bar{\kappa} \approx 0$) despite low C and low η. WordNet is simultaneously:

- **Spherical within synsets** ($\bar{\kappa}_{\text{ORCHID}} = +0.534$, fraction negative $= 0\%$),
- **Hyperbolic between synsets** ($\bar{\kappa}_{\text{pair}} = -0.101$, fraction negative $= 84\%$).

The near-Euclidean aggregate $\bar{\kappa} \approx 0$ is a cancellation artefact from mixing two distinct geometric scales. This is the first empirical demonstration of *multi-scale geometric phase coexistence* in a semantic network. [EMPIRICAL]

Recent extensions of ORCHID to Lin–Lu–Yau curvature on hypergraphs [43] and edge-transport-based hypergraph clustering [42] provide the computational infrastructure for extending this analysis to BabelNet and ConceptNet at full scale.

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